Benjamin

Britten

The Holy Sonnets of John Donne op 35

High voice & piano

BOOSEY & HAWKES

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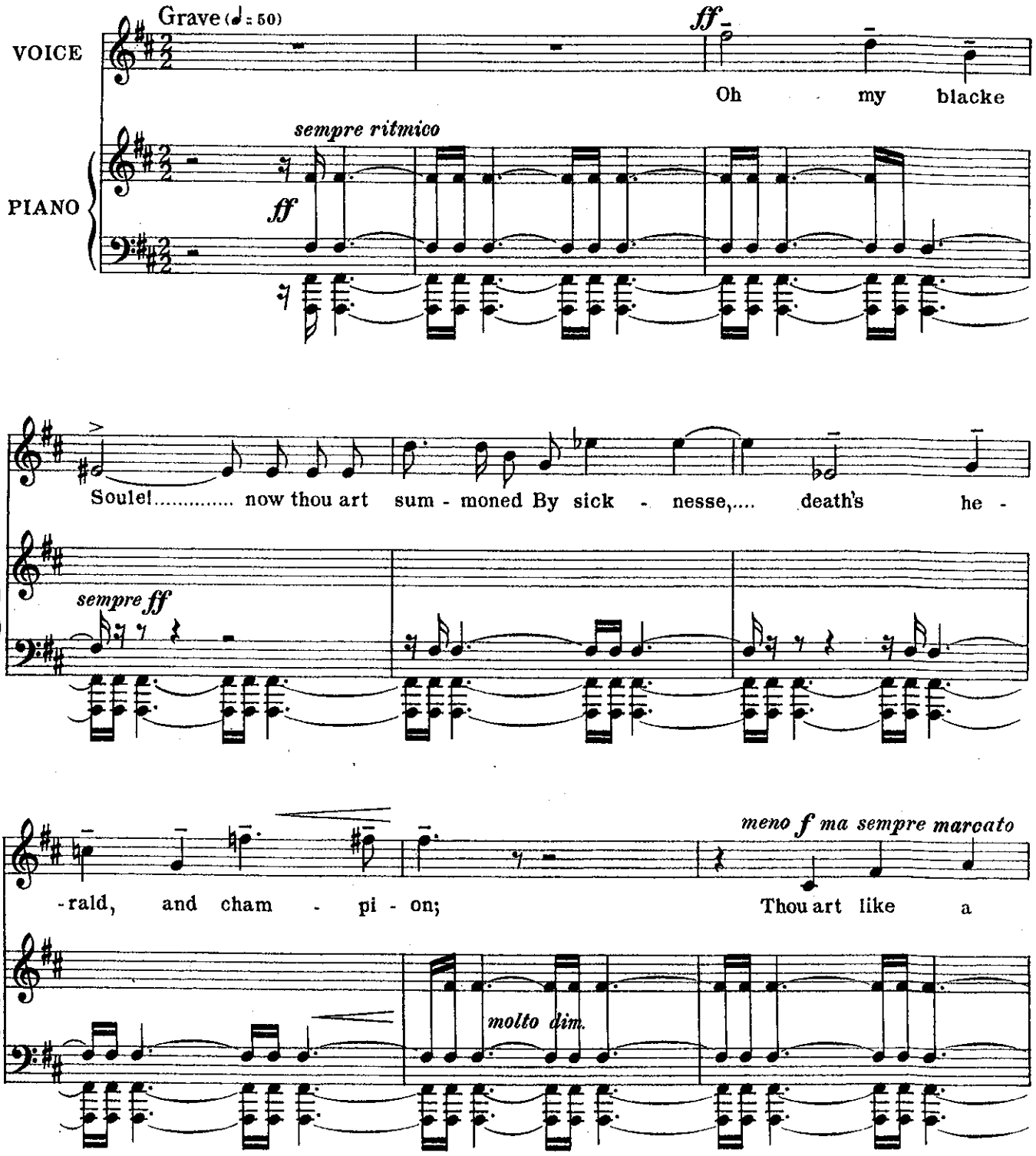
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For Peter

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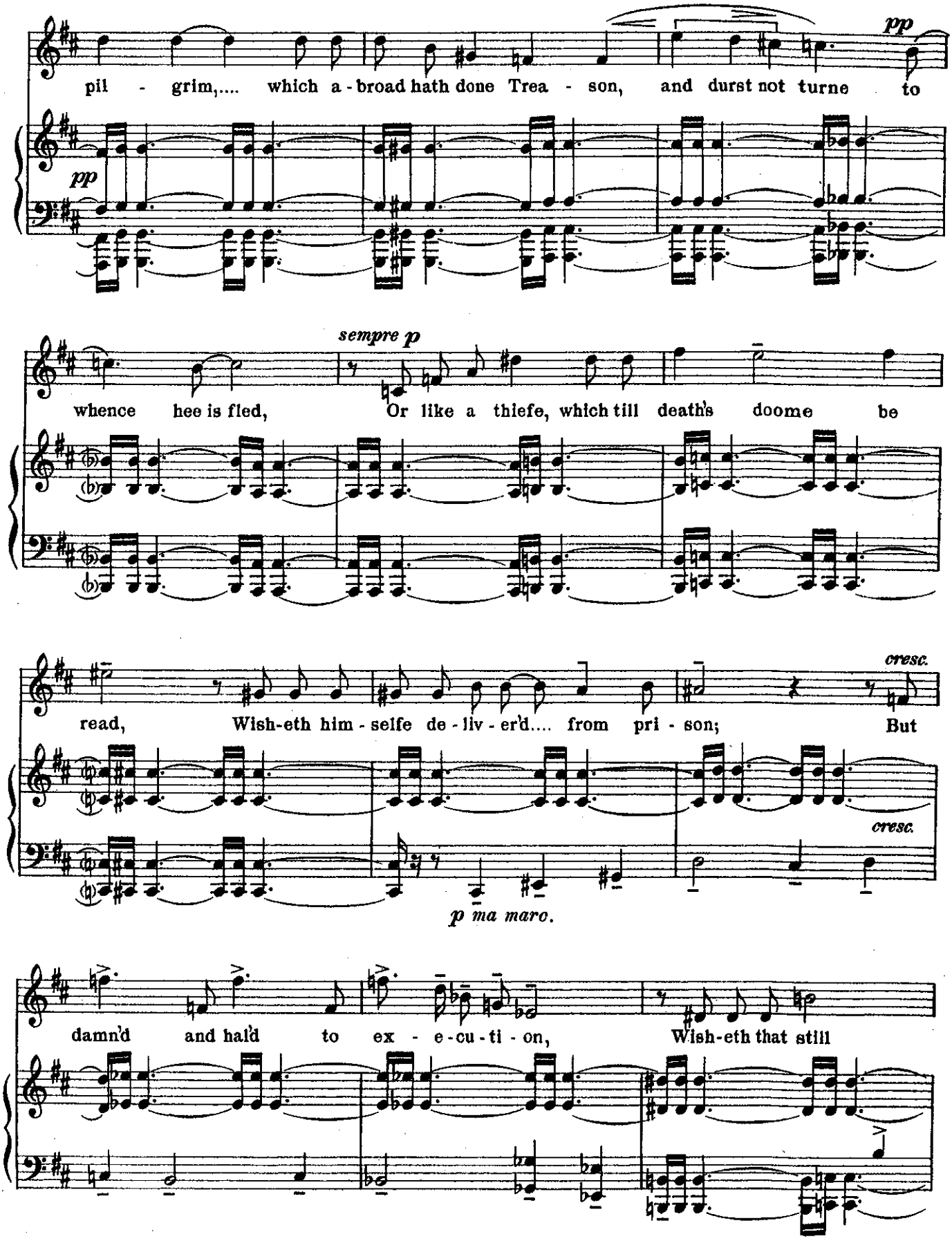
1. Oh my blacke Soule!
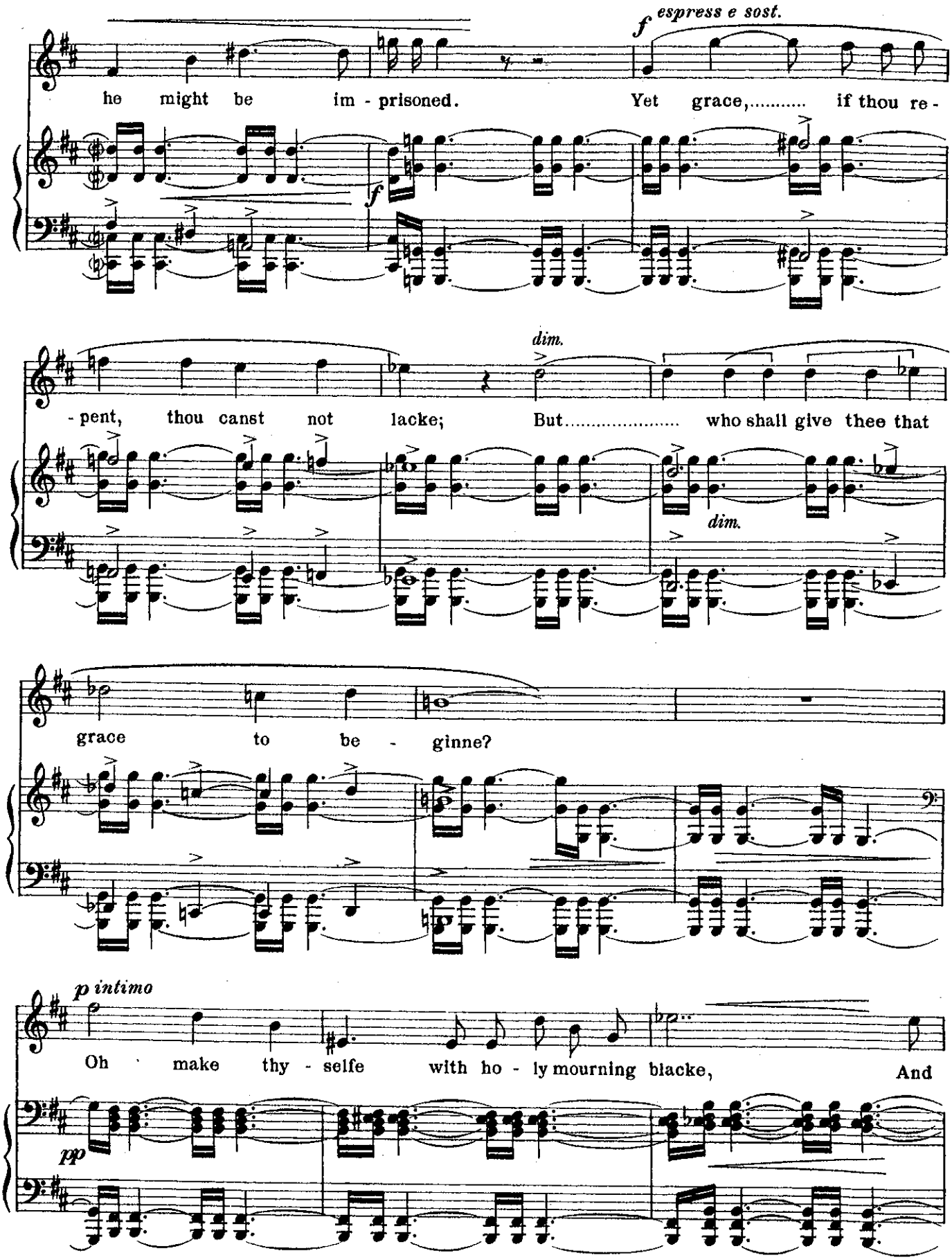
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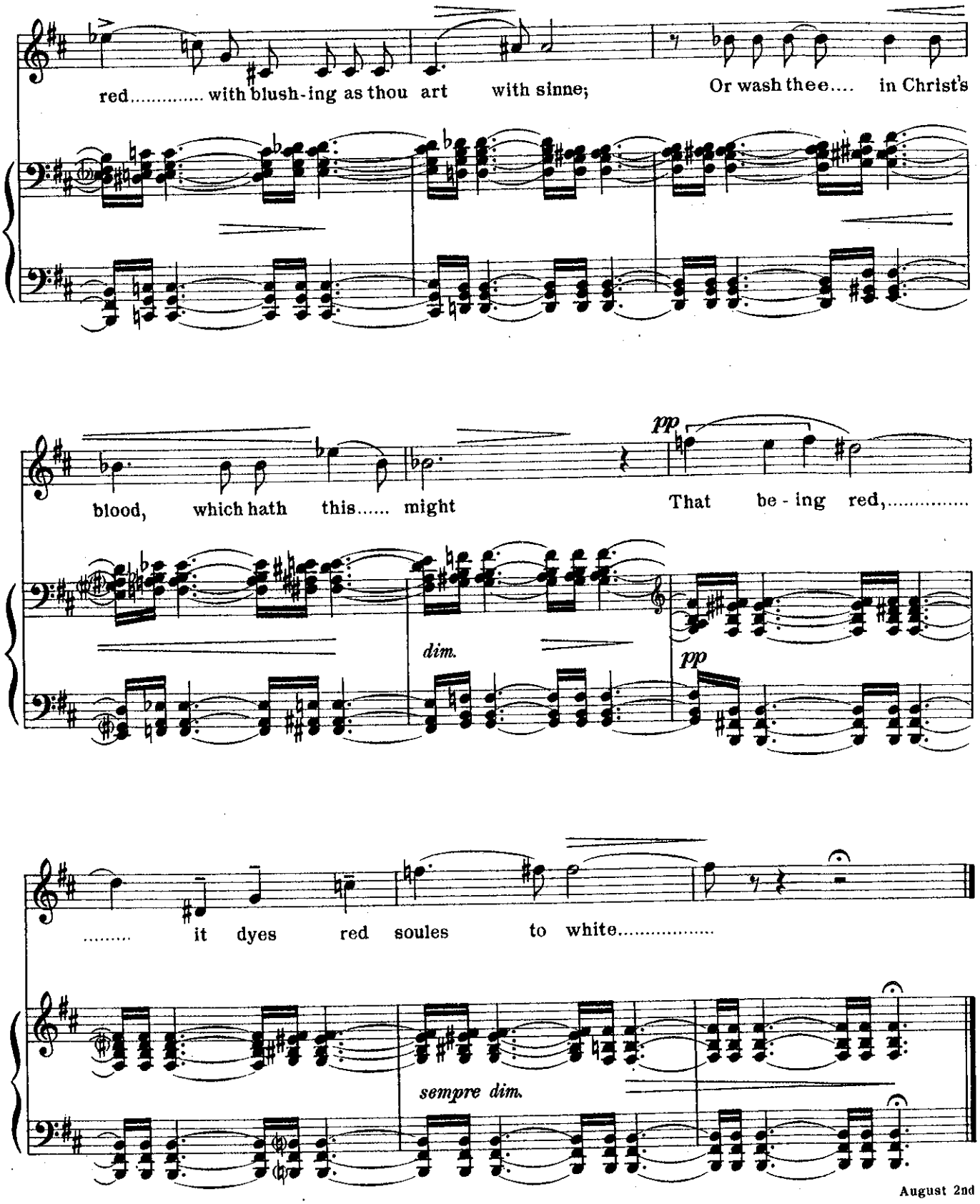


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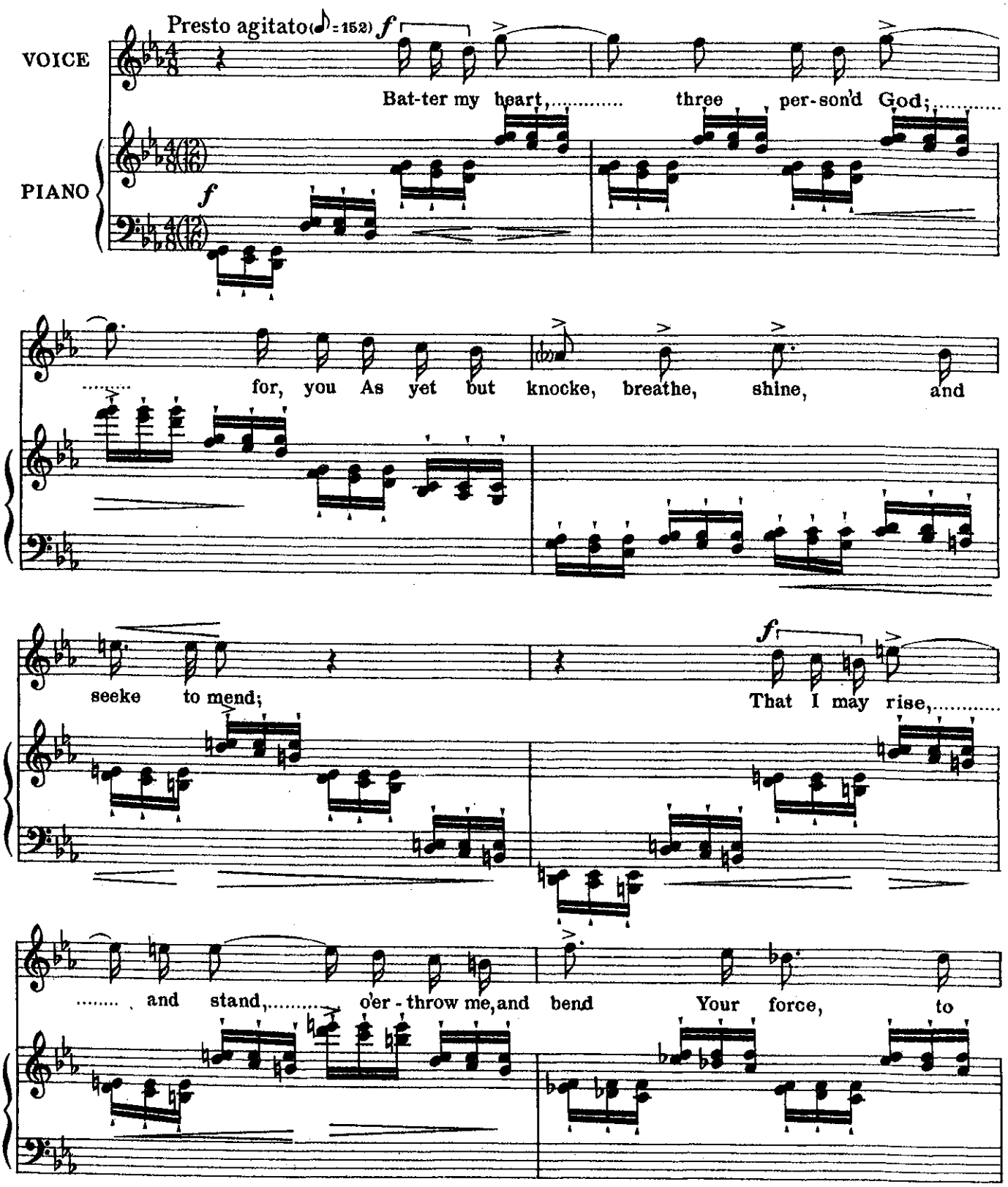
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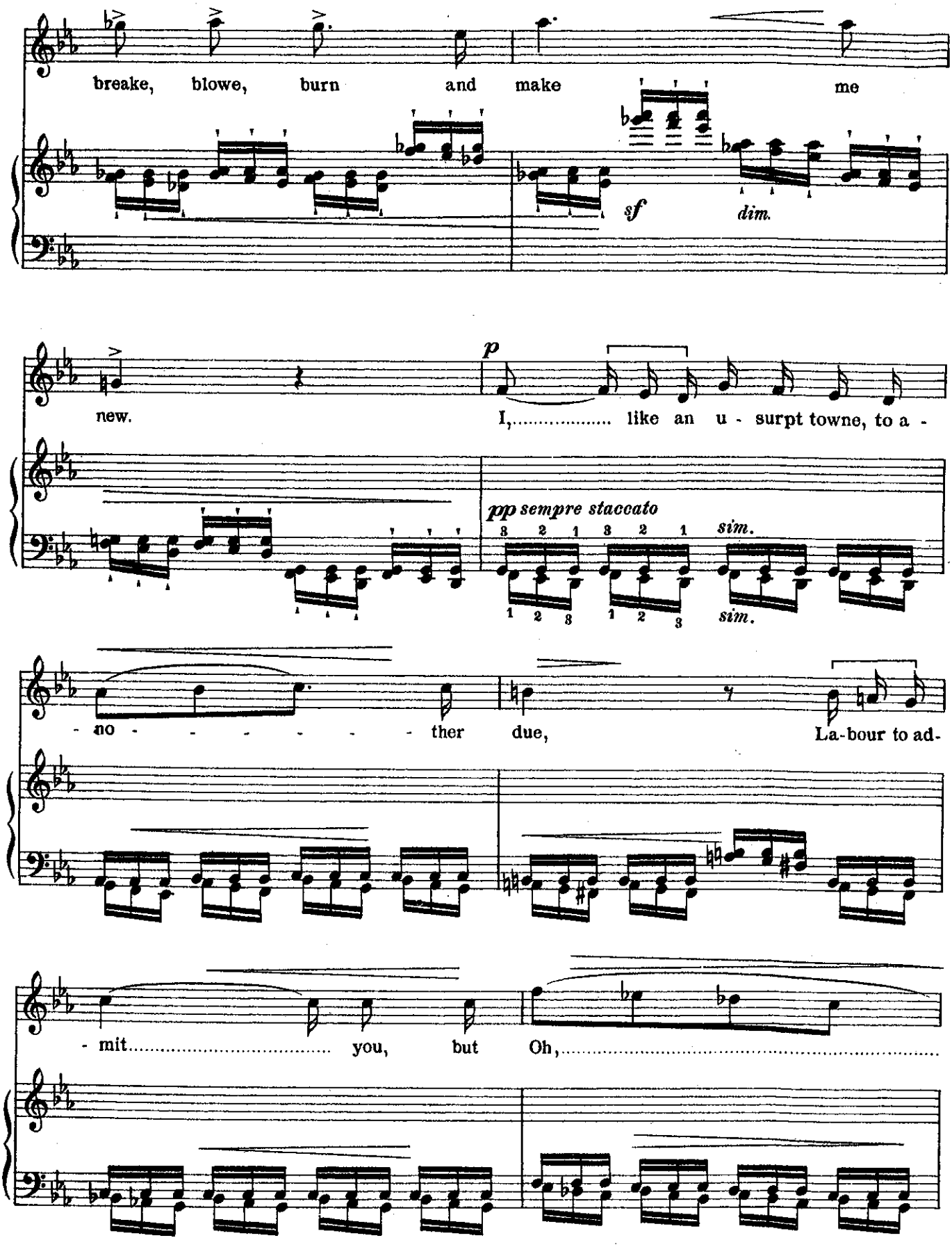

pp
pil - grim,.... which a-broad hath done Trea - son, and durst not turne to
pp
sempre p
whence hee is fled, Or like a thiefe, which till death's doome be
cresc.
read, Wish-eth him-selfe de-liv-er'd.... from pri-son; But
cresc.
p ma maro.
damn'd and hal'd to ex - e-cu-ti - on, Wish-eth that still
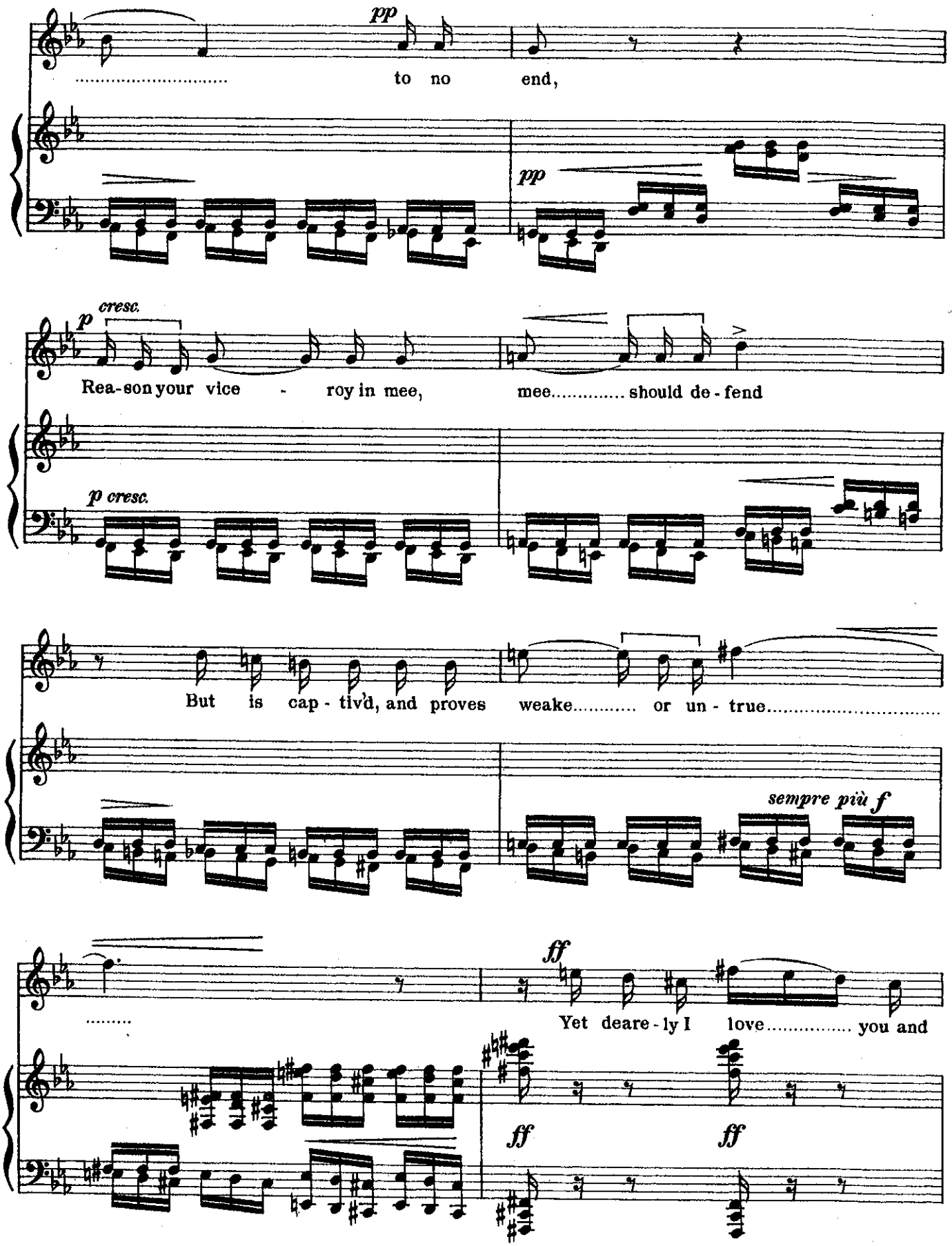

f espress e sost.
he might be im - prisoned. Yet grace,..... if thou re -
f
dim.
- pent, thou canst not lacke; But..... who shall give thee that
dim.
grace to be - ginne?
p intimo
Oh make thy - selfe with ho - ly mourning blacke, And
pp
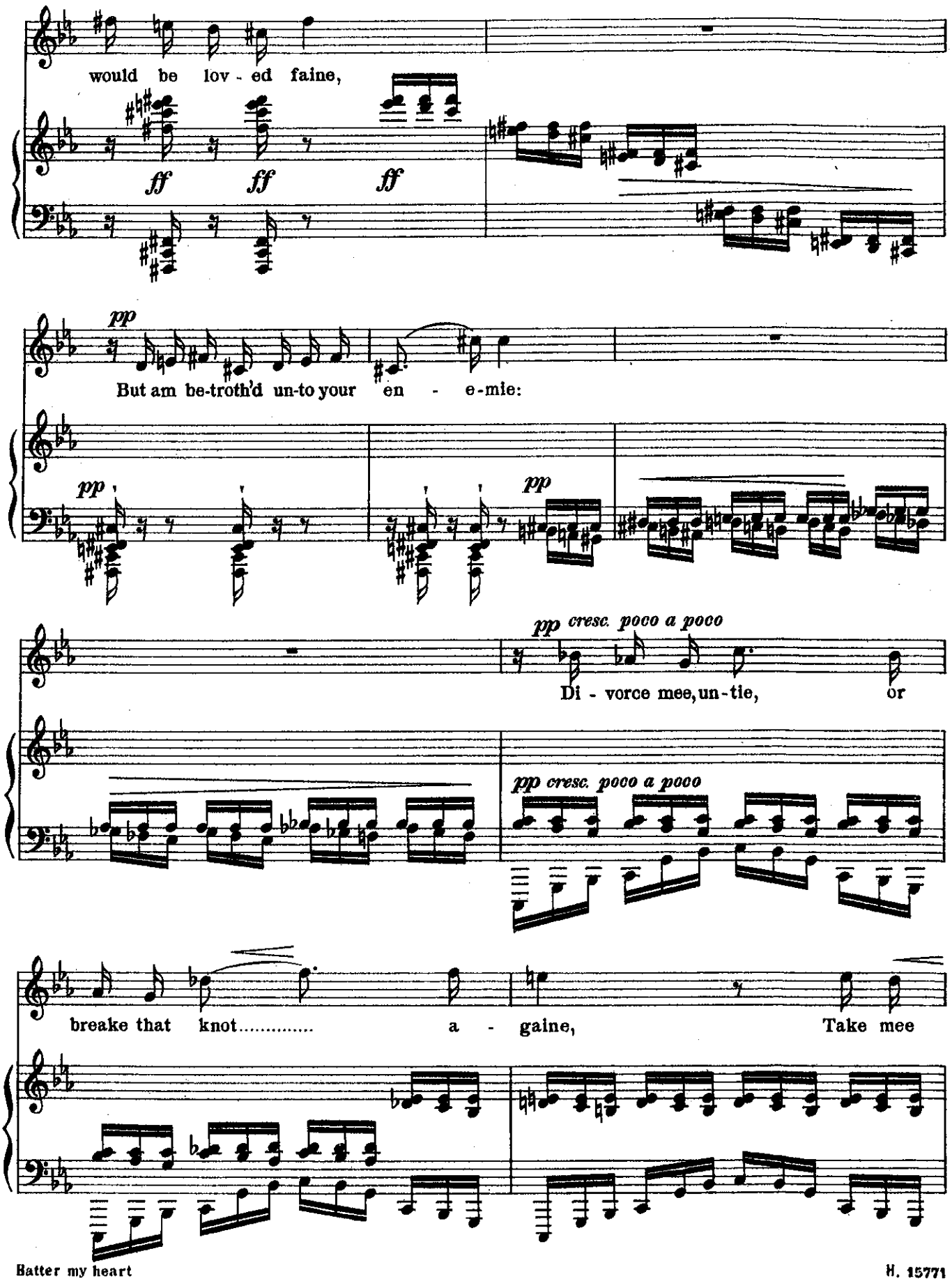

red..... with blush-ing as thou art with sinne; Or wash thee.... in Christ's
blood, which hath this..... might That be - ing red,.....
pp
dim.
pp
..... it dyes red soules to white.....
sempre dim.
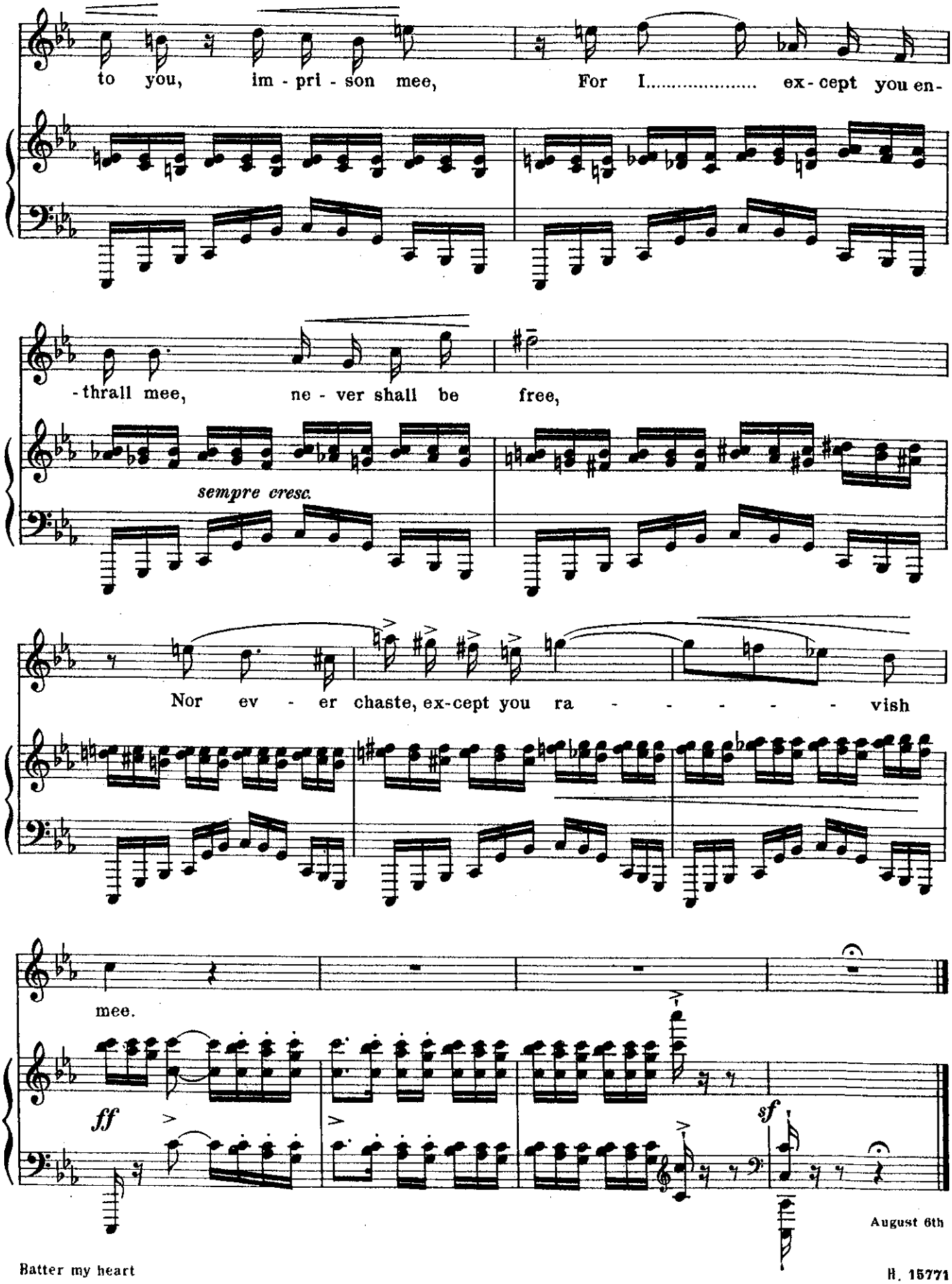
2. Batter my heart
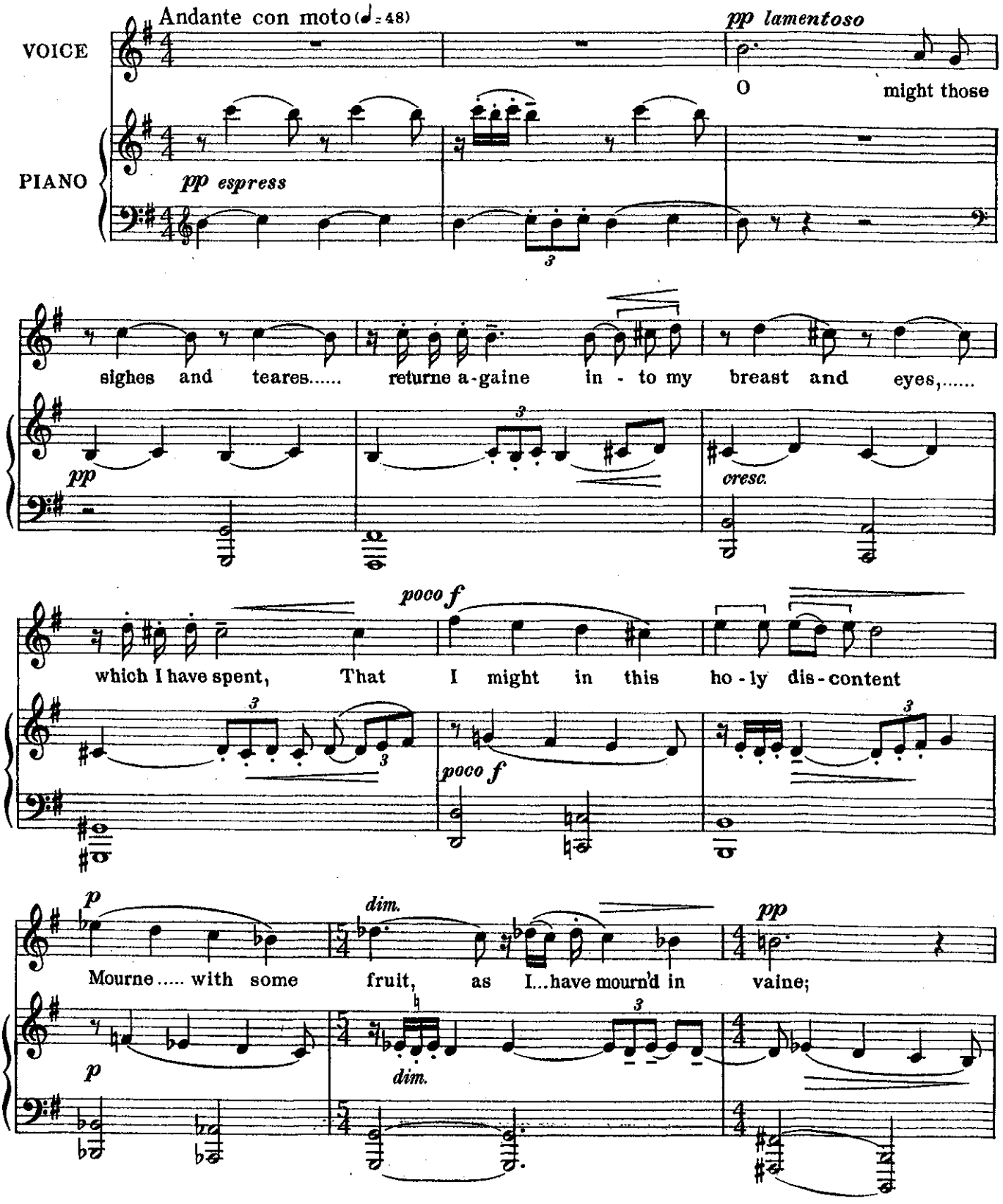



breake, blowe, burn and make me
sf
dim.
new.
p
I, ... like an u - surpt towne, to a -
pp sempre staccato
sim.
sim.
- no - - - - - - - ther due, La-bour to ad-
- mit ..... you, but Oh, ...
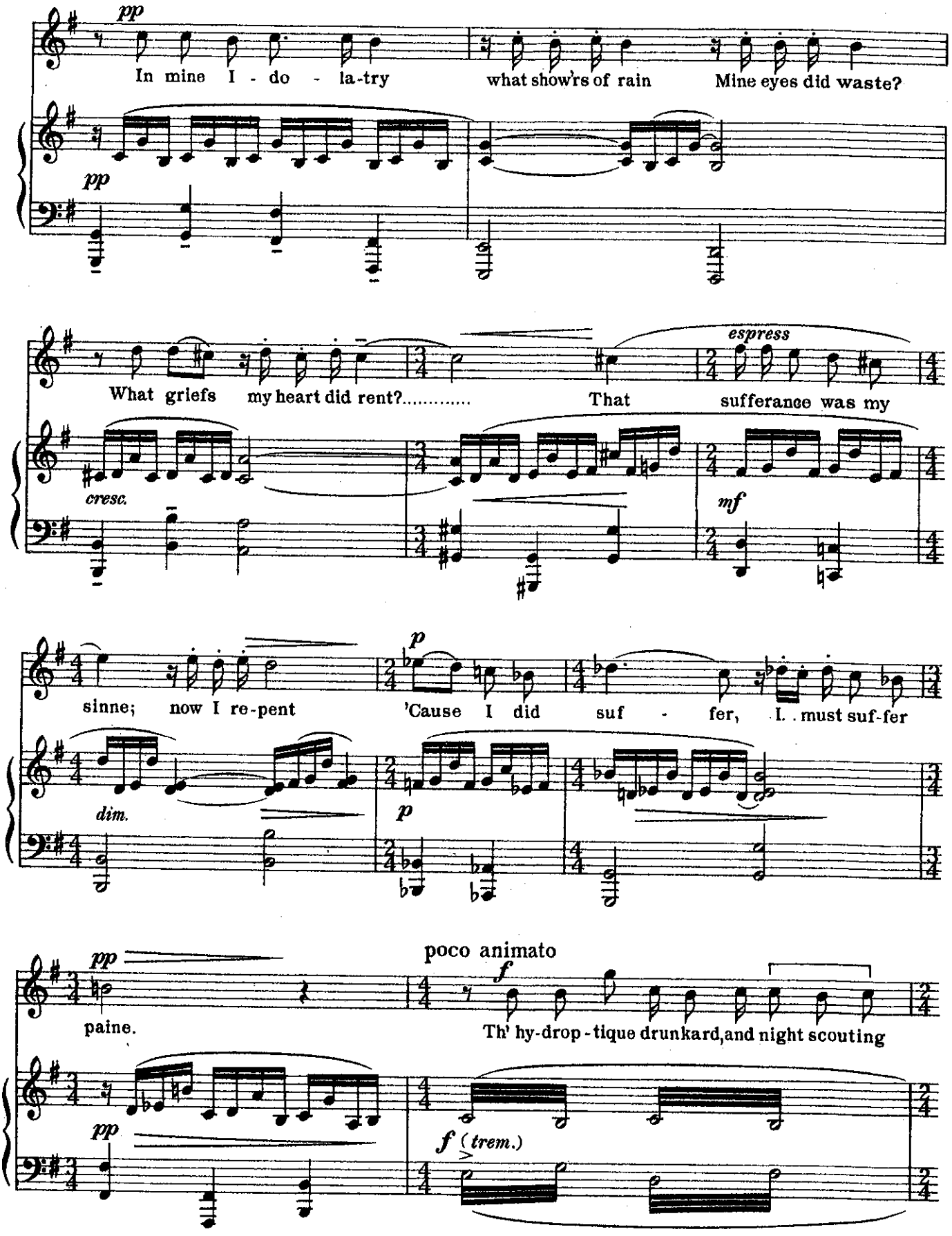

pp
to no end,
pp
p cresc.
Rea-son your vice - roy in mee, mee..... should de - fend
p cresc.
But is cap - tiv'd, and proves weake..... or un - true.....
sempre più f
ff
Yet deare - ly I love..... you and
ff
ff


would be lov - ed faine,
ff ff ff
pp
But am be-troth'd un-to your en - e-mie:
pp pp
pp cresc. poco a poco
Di - vorce mee, un-tie, or
pp cresc. poco a poco
breake that knot..... a - gaine, Take mee
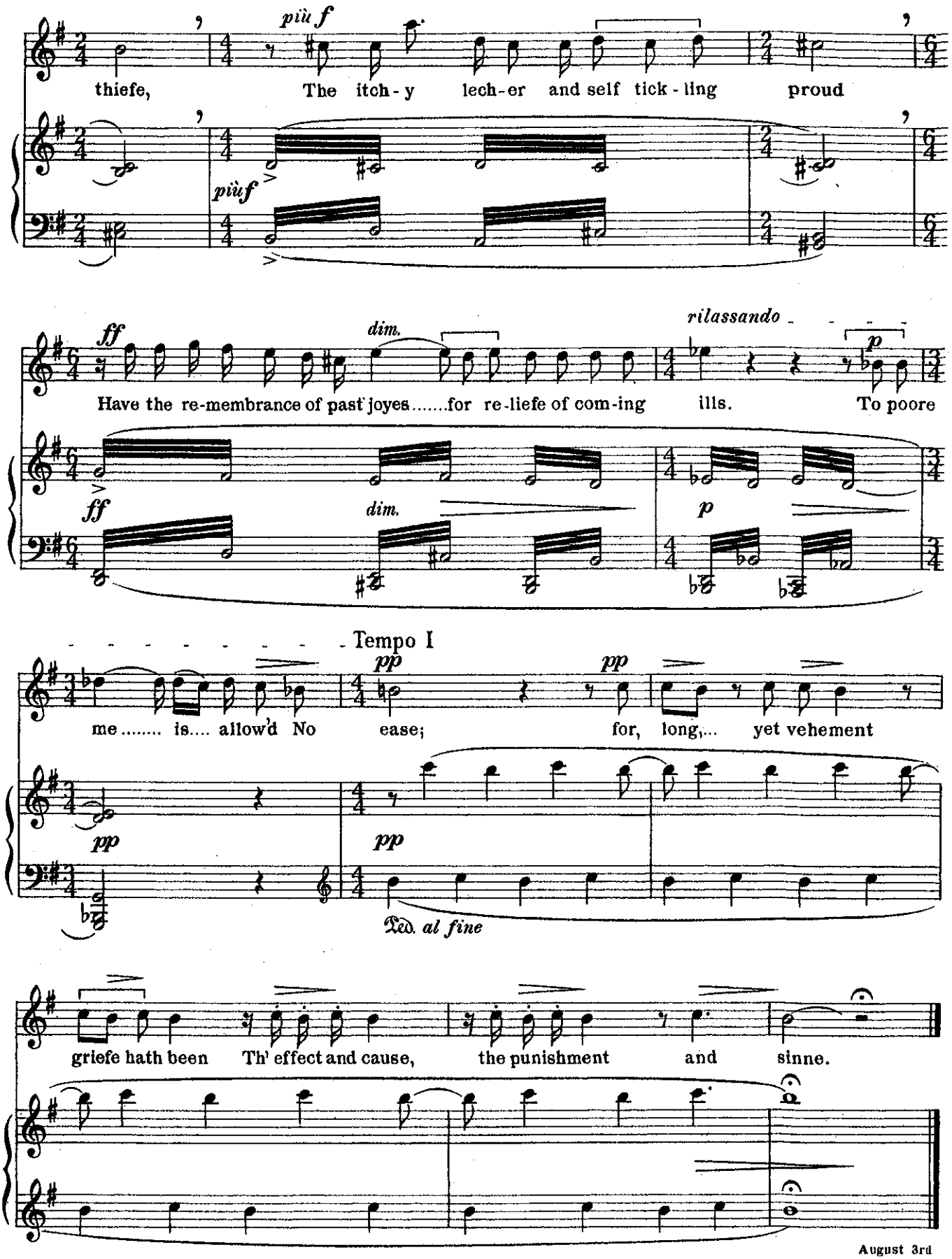

to you, im - pri - son mee, For I..... ex - cept you en-
-thrall mee, ne - ver shall be free,
sempre cresc.
Nor ev - er chaste, ex-cept you ra - - - - - - vish
mee.
ff
sf

3. O might those sighes and teares
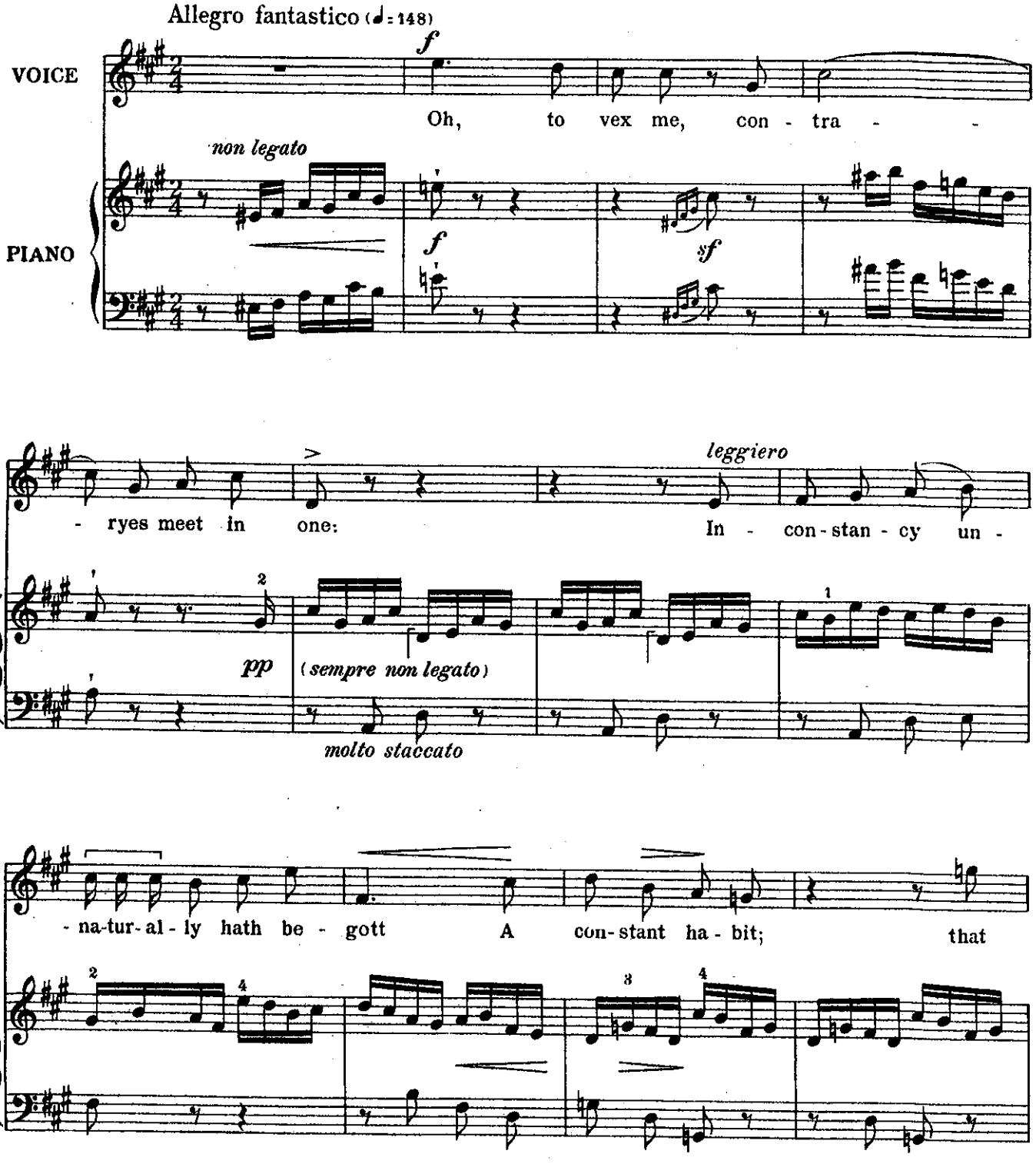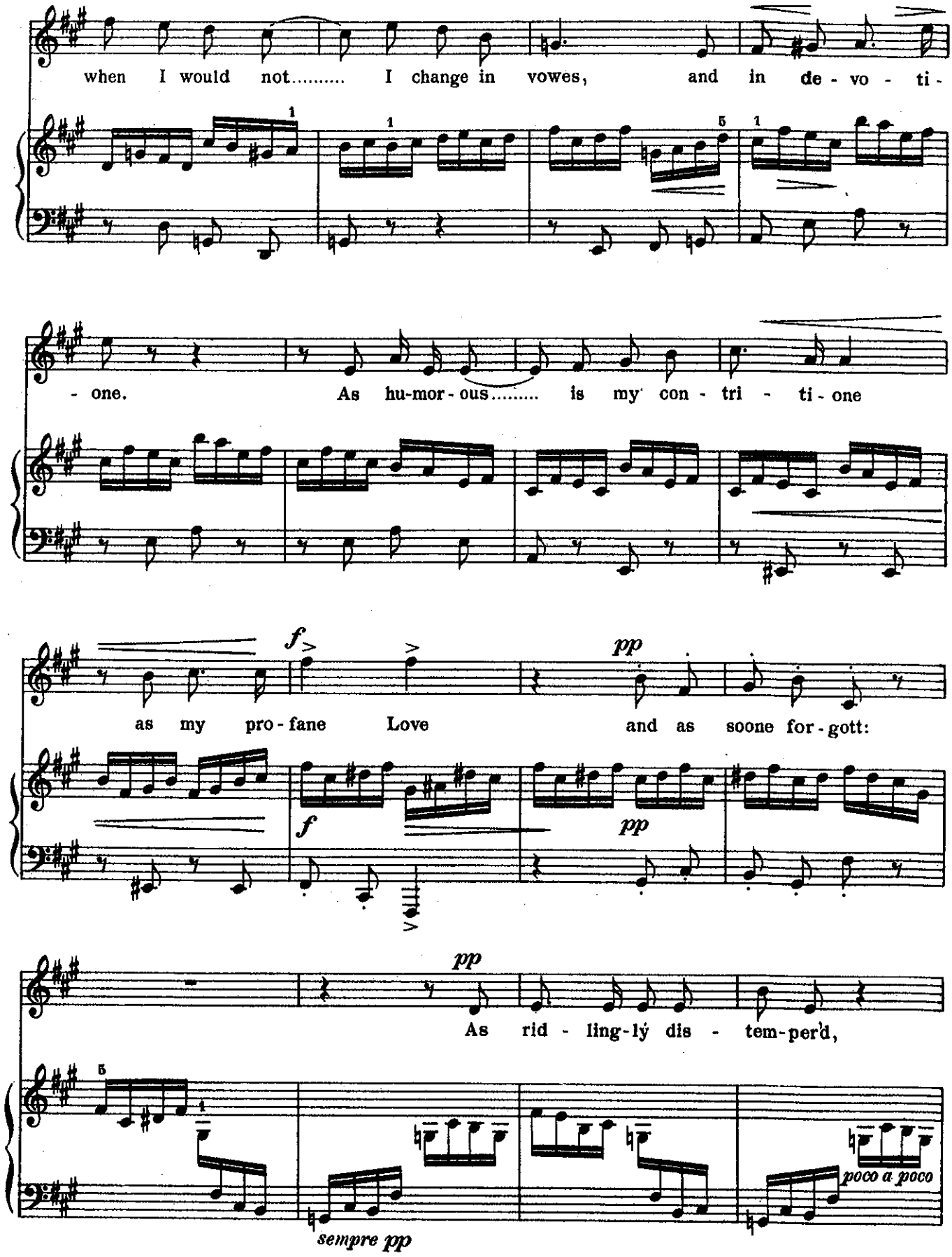




O might those sighes and teares
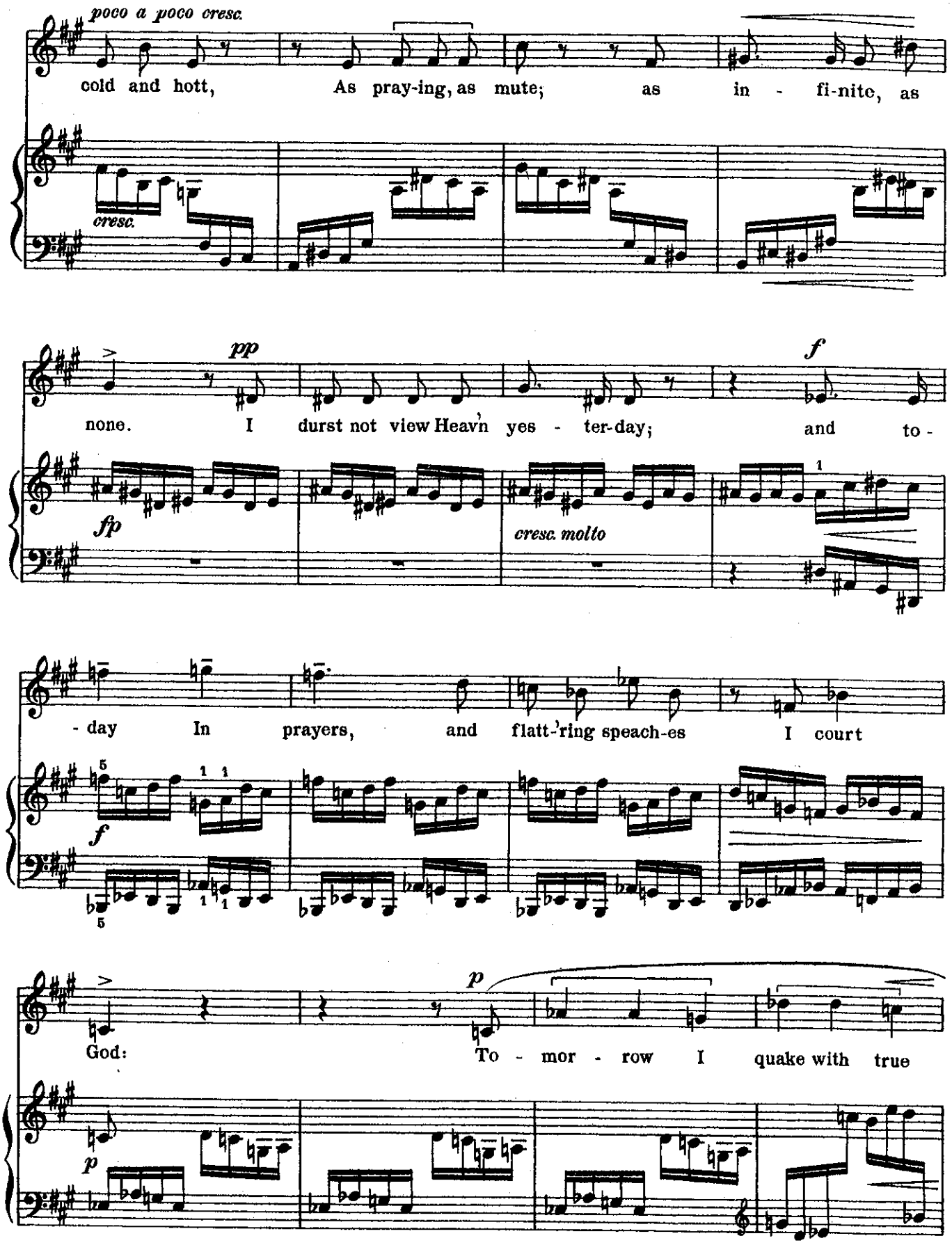

più f
thiefe, The itch - y lech - er and self tick - ling proud
più f
ff
dim.
rilassando
Have the re - membrance of past joyes.....for re - liefe of com - ing ills. To poore
ff
dim.
p
Tempo I
me..... is.... allow'd No ease; for, long,... yet vehement
pp
pp
pp
pp
Ped. al fine
griefe hath been Th' effect and cause, the punishment and sinne.
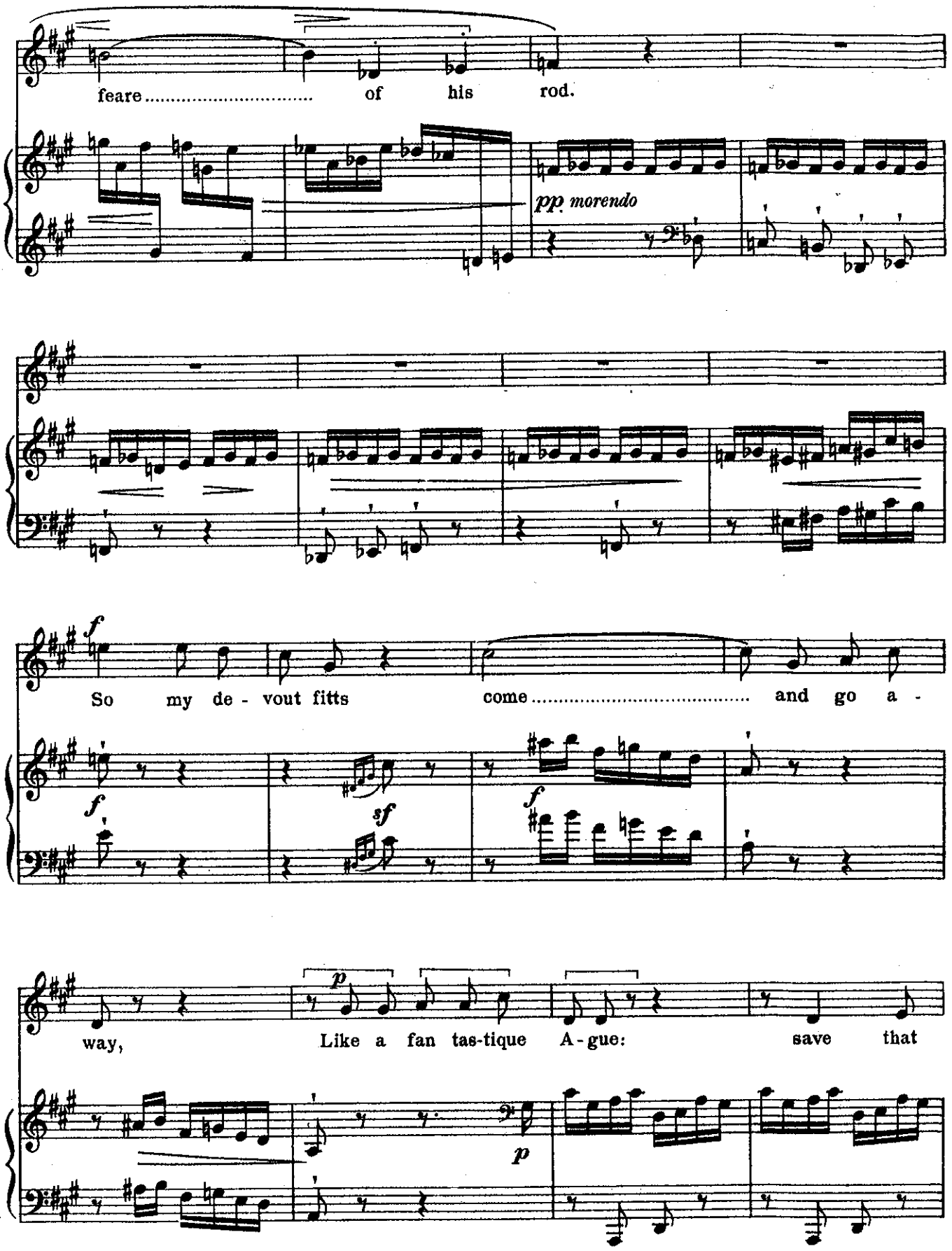
4. Oh, to vex me
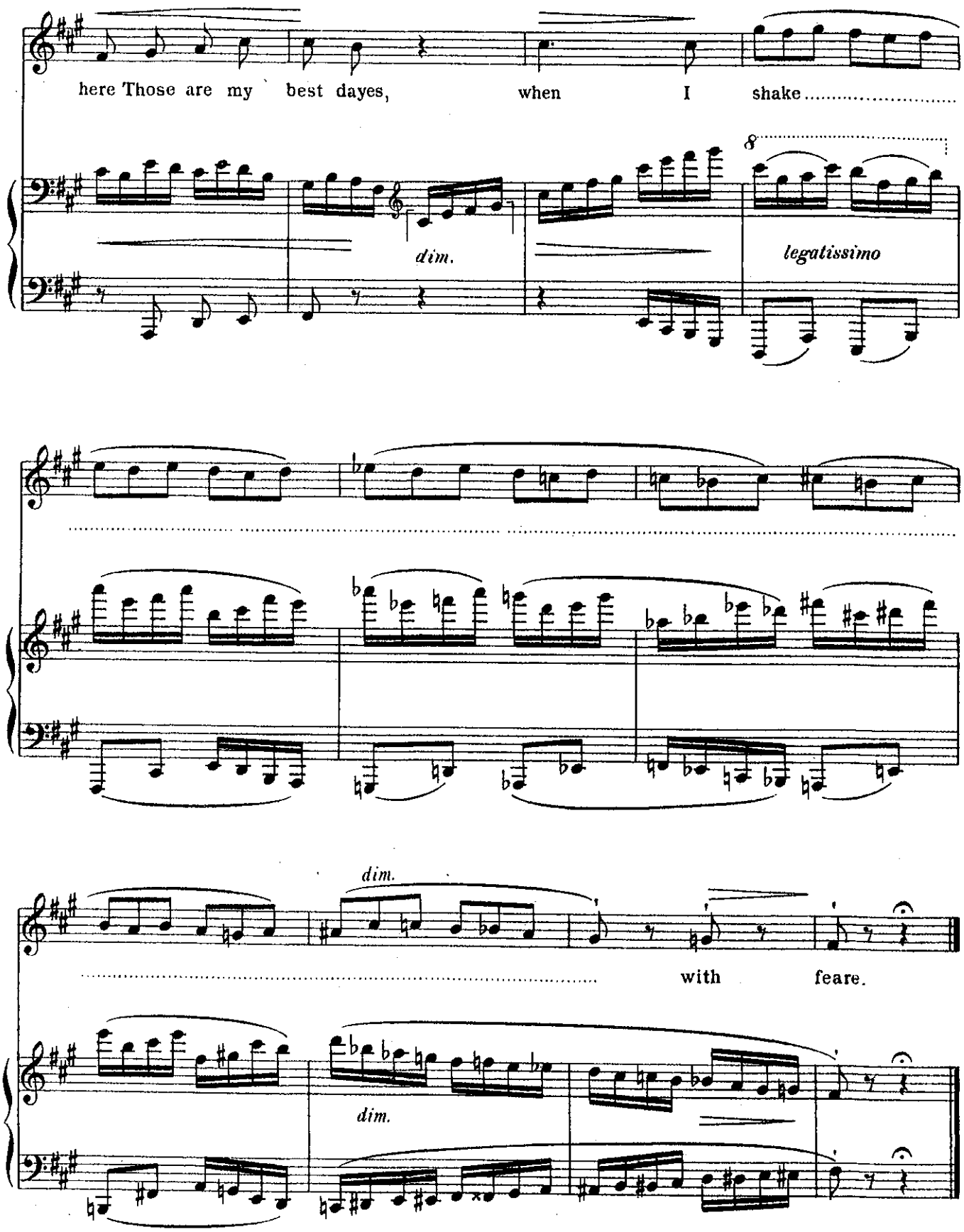

Allegro fantastico (♩= 148)
VOICE
PIANO
f
Oh, to vex me, con - tra - -
non legato
f
sf
- ryes meet in one:
In - con - stan - cy un -
leggiero
pp
(sempre non legato)
molto staccato
- na-tur-al - ly hath be - gott A con-stant ha - bit; that


when I would not..... I change in vowes, and in de - vo - ti -
- one. As hu-mor - ous..... is my con - tri - ti - one
as my pro - fane Love and as soone for - gott:
As rid - ling-ly dis - tem-per'd,
poco a poco
sempre pp

Oh, to vex me


poco a poco cresc.
cold and hott, As pray-ing, as mute; as in - fi-nite, as
cresc.
pp
f
none. I durst not view Heav'n yes - ter-day; and to -
fp
cresc. molto
- day In prayers, and flatt-'ring speach-es I court
f
p
God: To - mor - row I quake with true
p
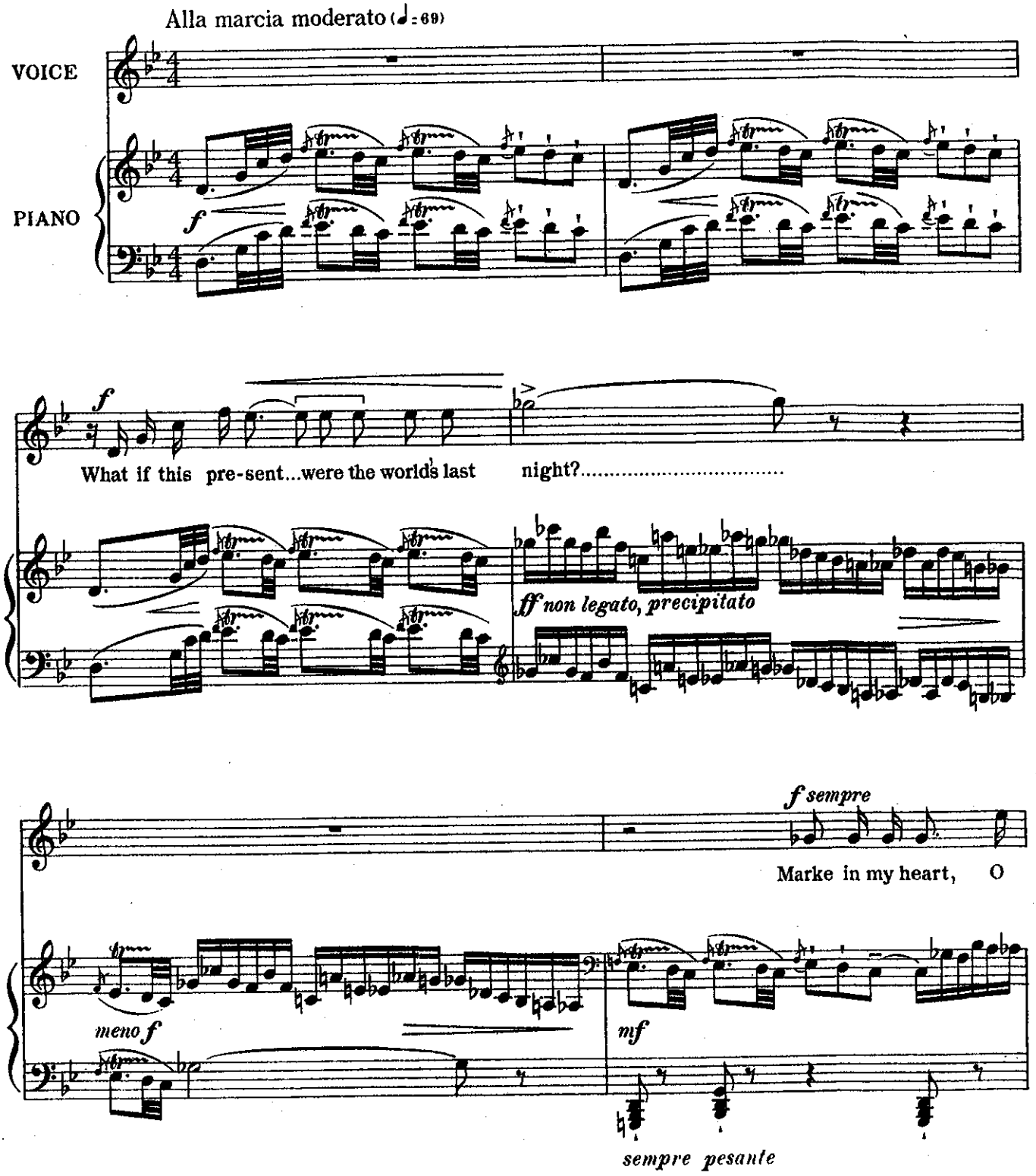

feare ..... of his rod.
pp morendo
So my de - vout fitts come ..... and go a -
f
sf
f
way, Like a fan tas-tique A-gue: save that
p
p
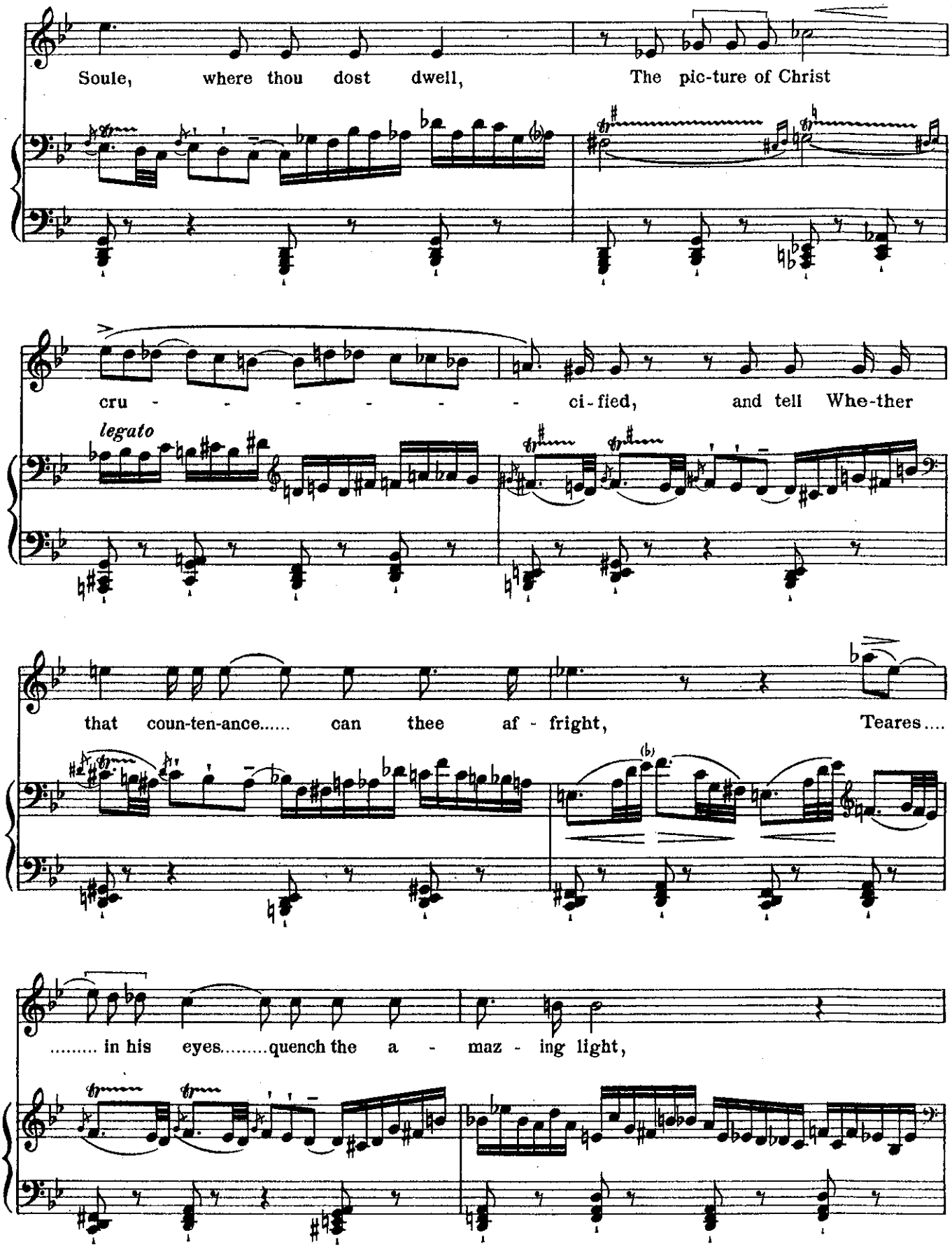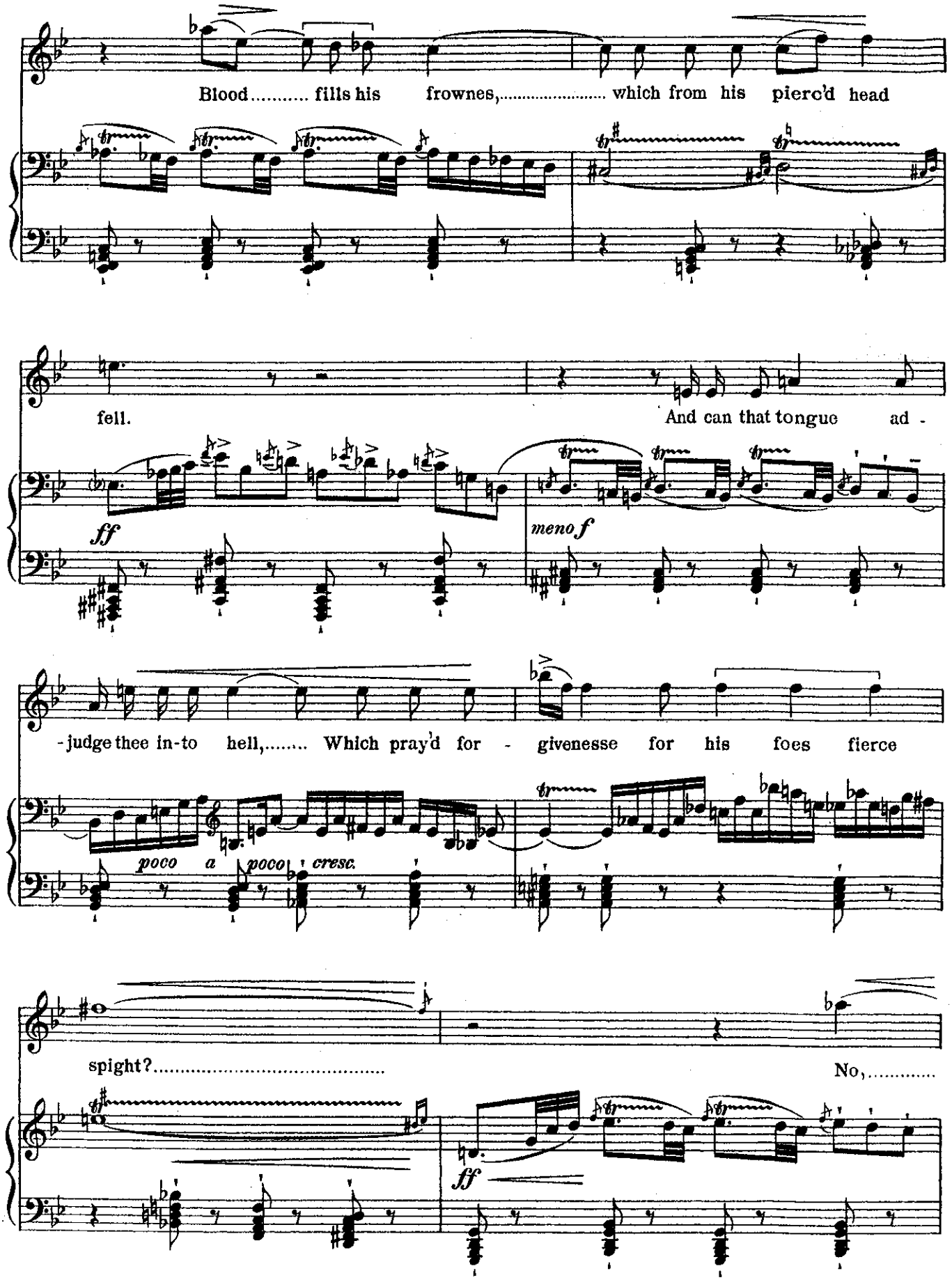


August 7th.
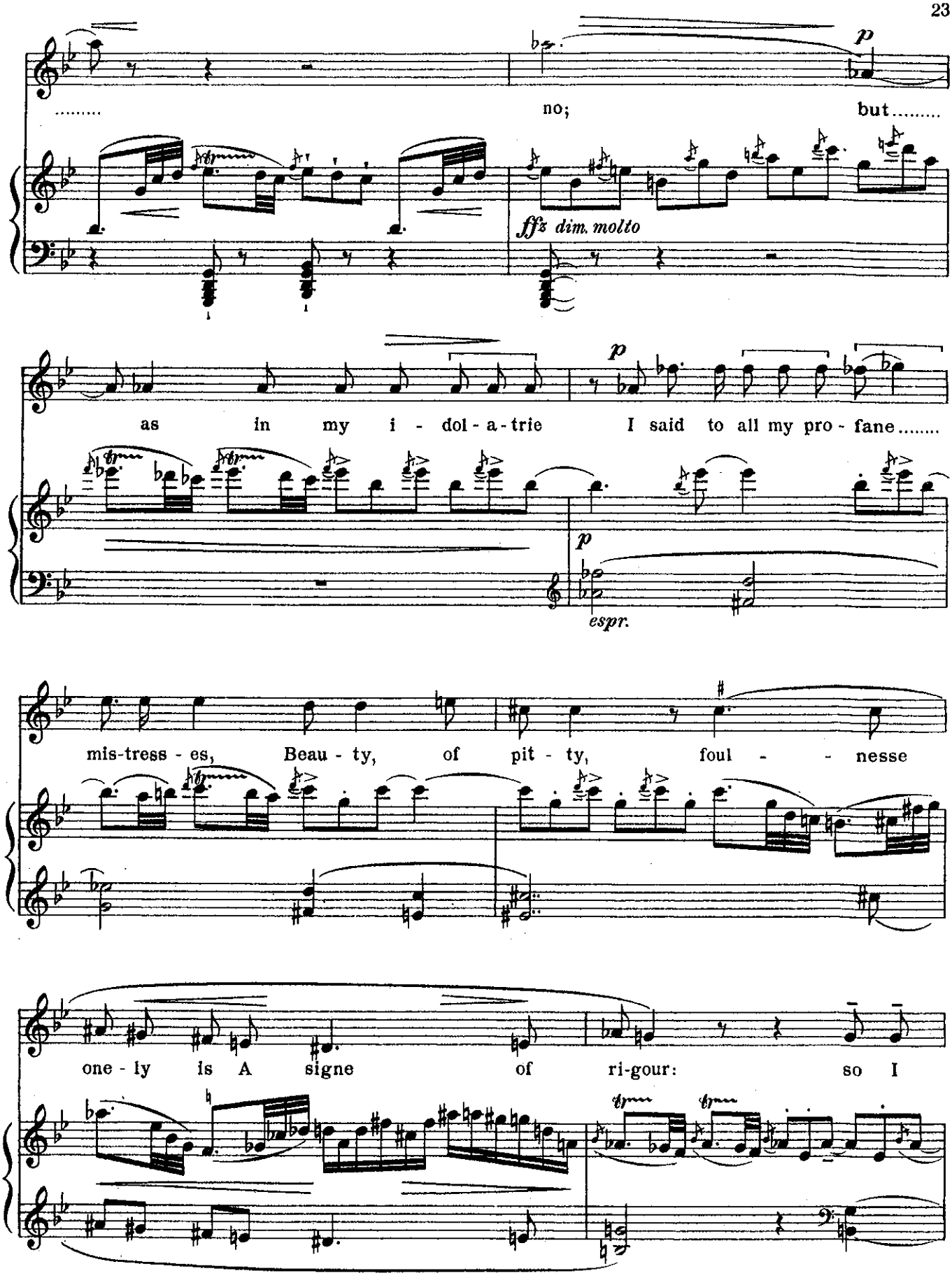
Oh, to vex me
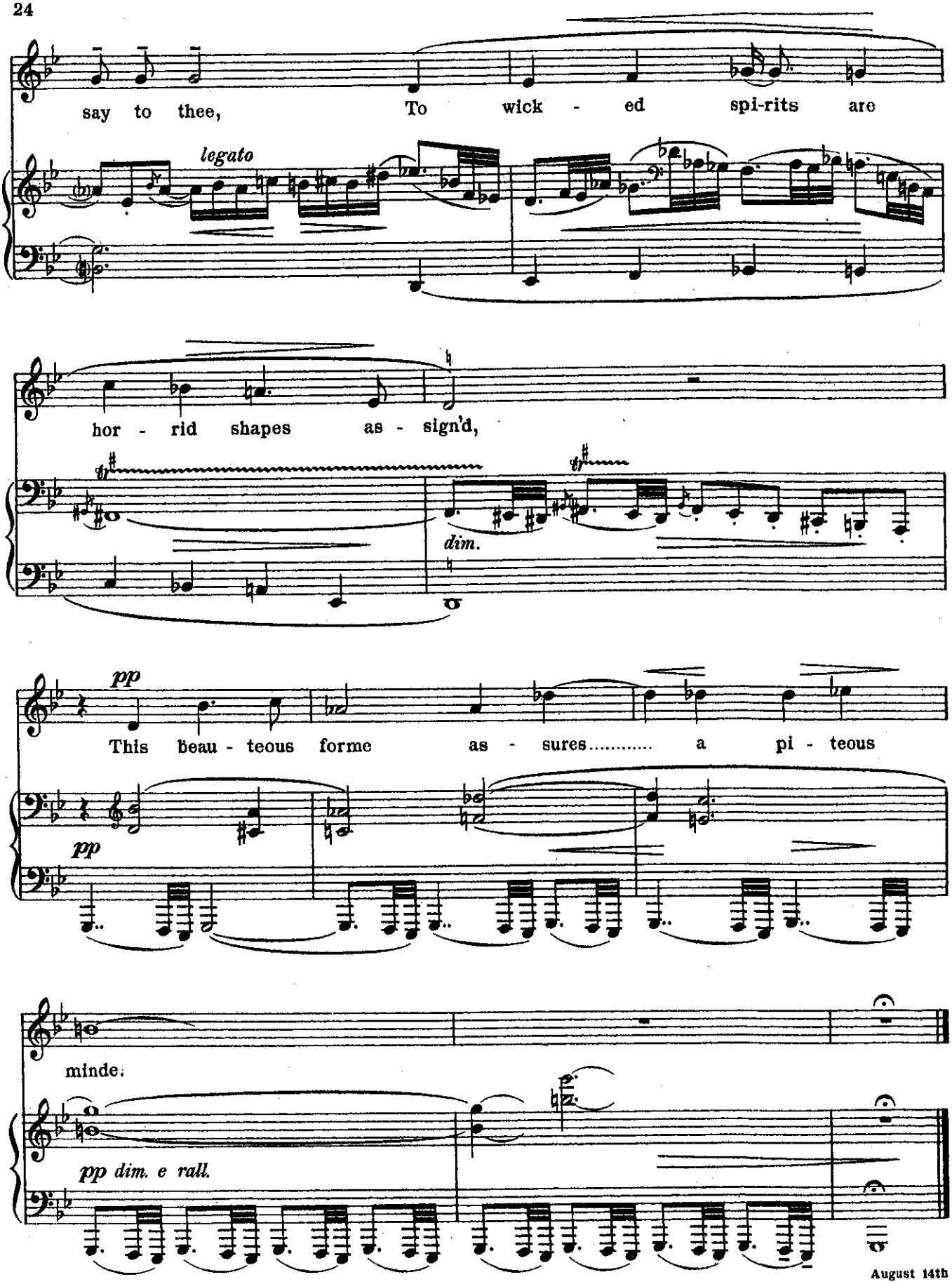
5. What if this present



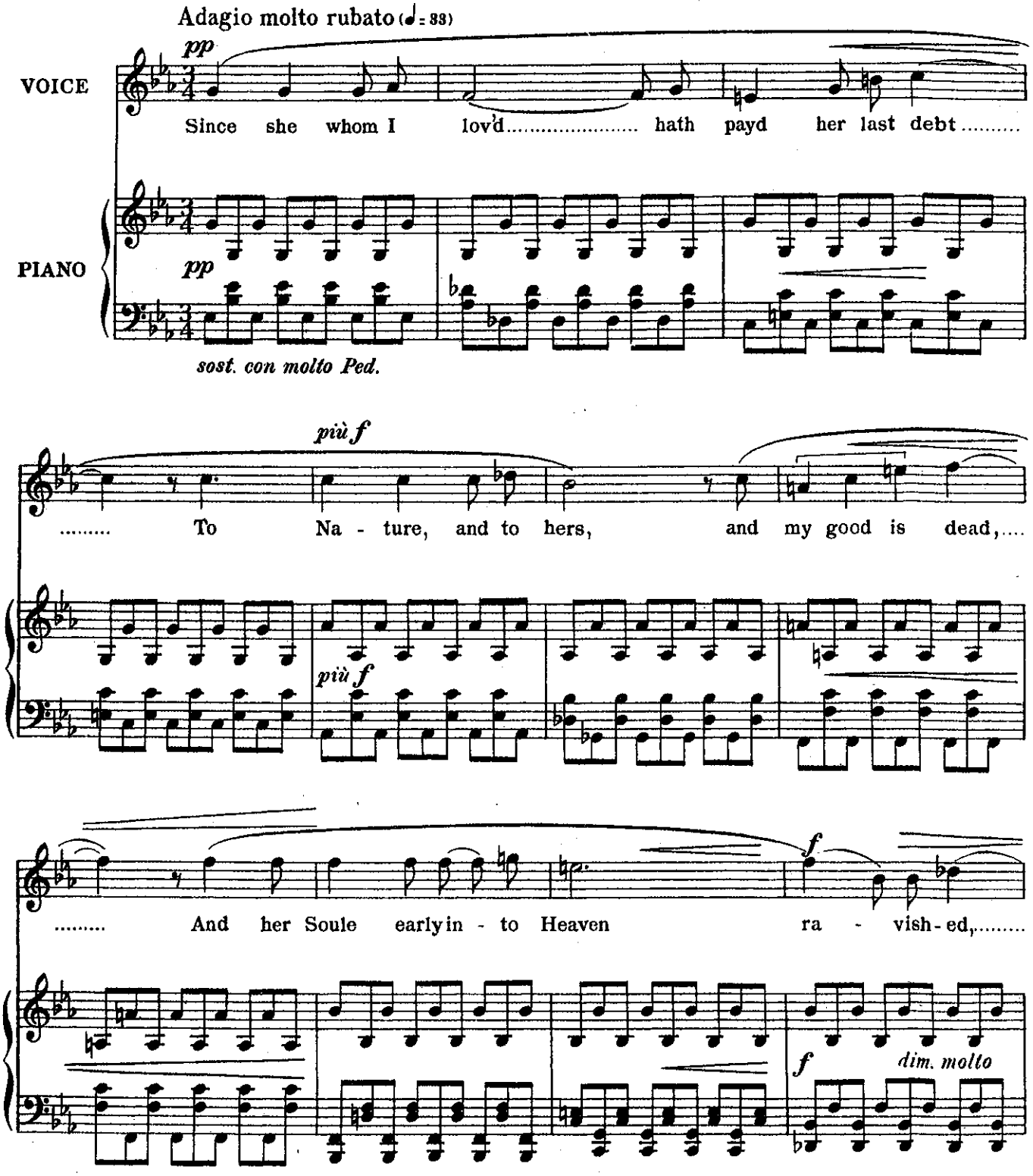

Soule, where thou dost dwell, The pic-ture of Christ
cru - - - - - - - ci-fied, and tell Whe-ther
legato
that coun-ten-ance..... can thee af - fright, Teares....
..... in his eyes.....quench the a - maz - ing light,
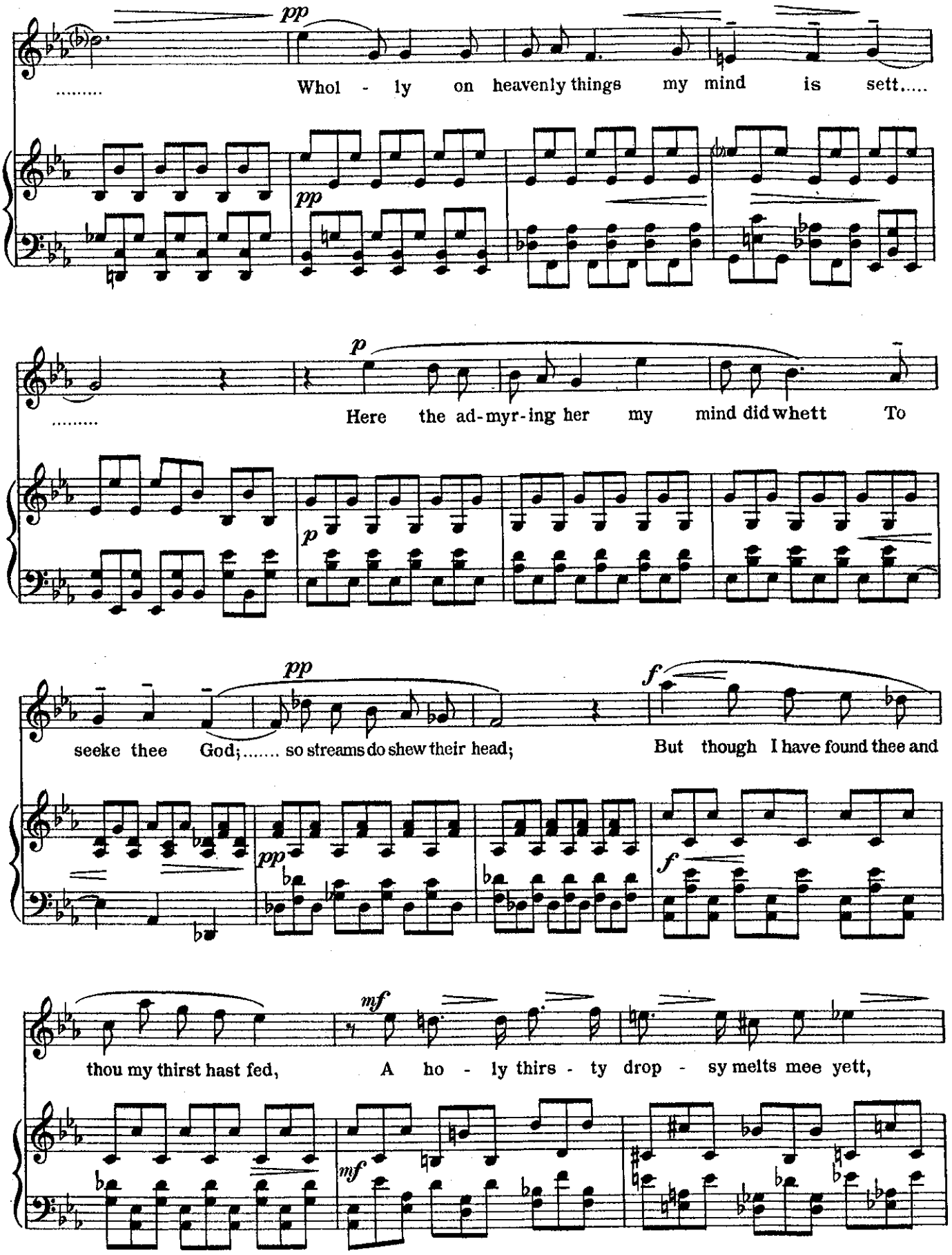

Blood..... fills his frownes,..... which from his pierc'd head
fell.
And can that tongue ad -
ff
meno f
-judge thee in-to hell,..... Which pray'd for - givenesse for his foes fierce
poco a poco cresc.
spight?.....
No,.....
ff
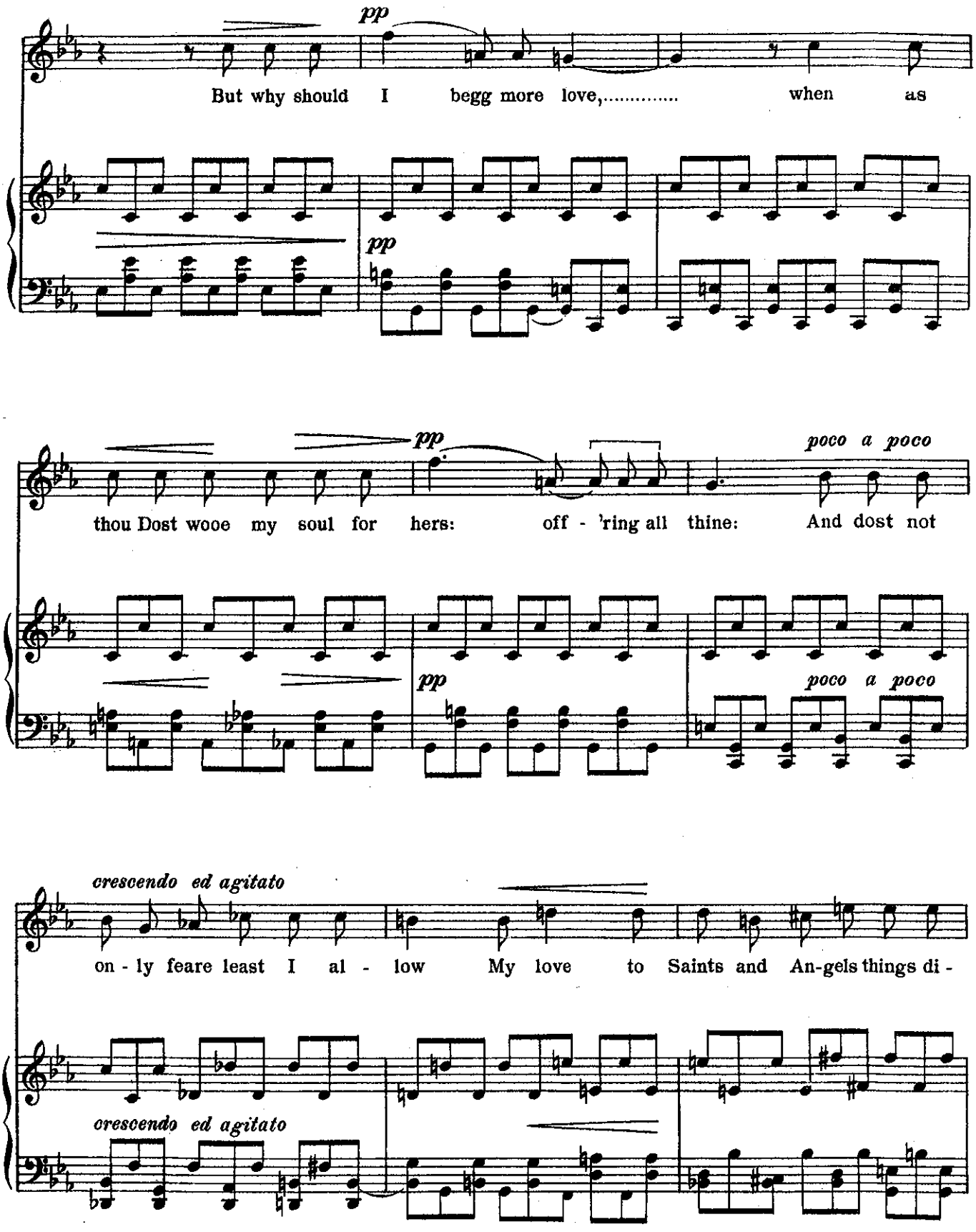

.....
no;
but.....
fffz dim. molto
as in my i - dol - a - trie
I said to all my pro - fane.....
espr.
mis-tress - es, Beau - ty, of pit - ty, foul - - nesse
one - ly is A signe of ri-gour: so I
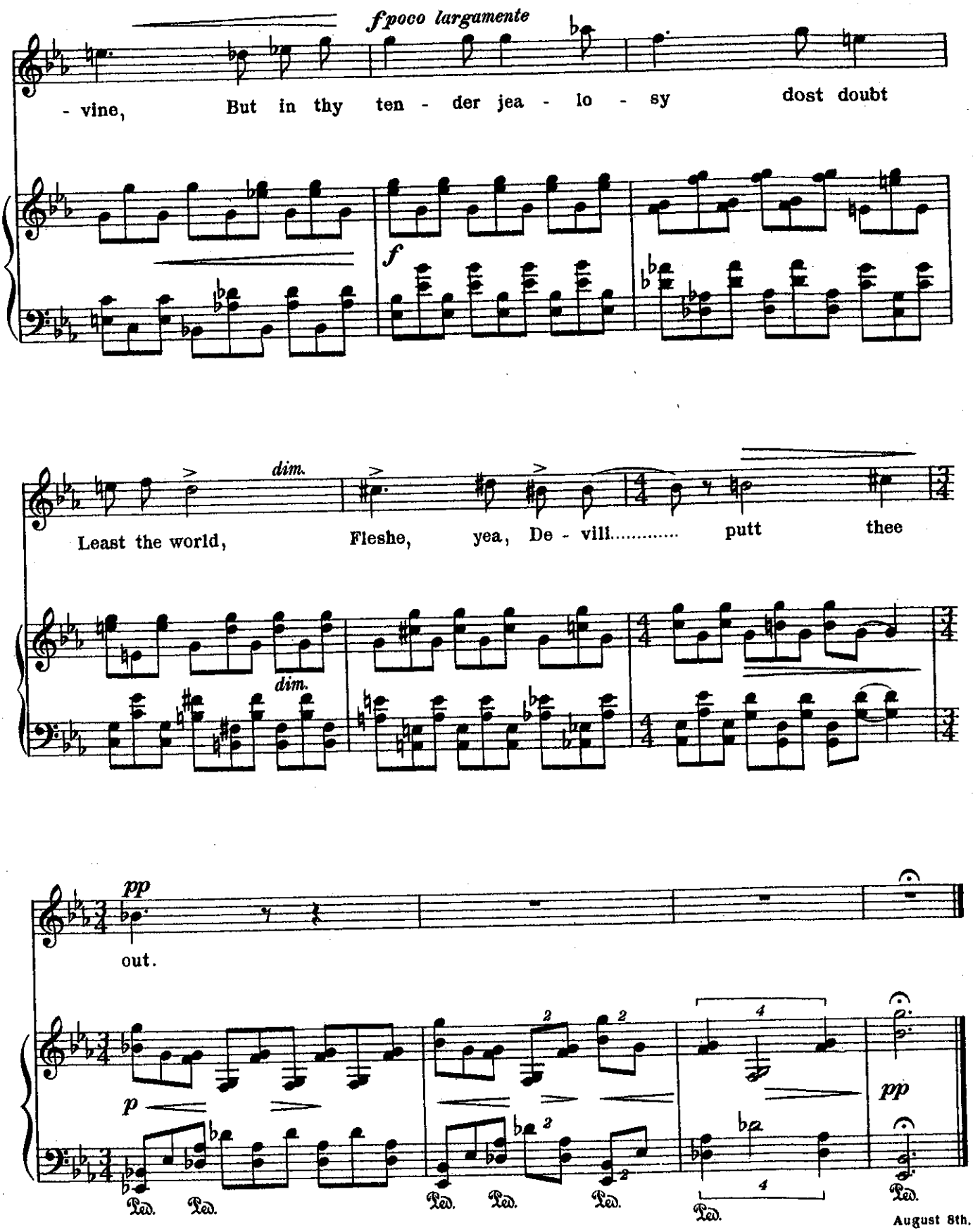

say to thee, To wick - ed spi-rits are
legato
hor - rid shapes as - sign'd,
dim.
pp
This beau - teous forme as - sures..... a pi - teous
pp
minde.
pp dim. e rall.

6. Since she whom I loved
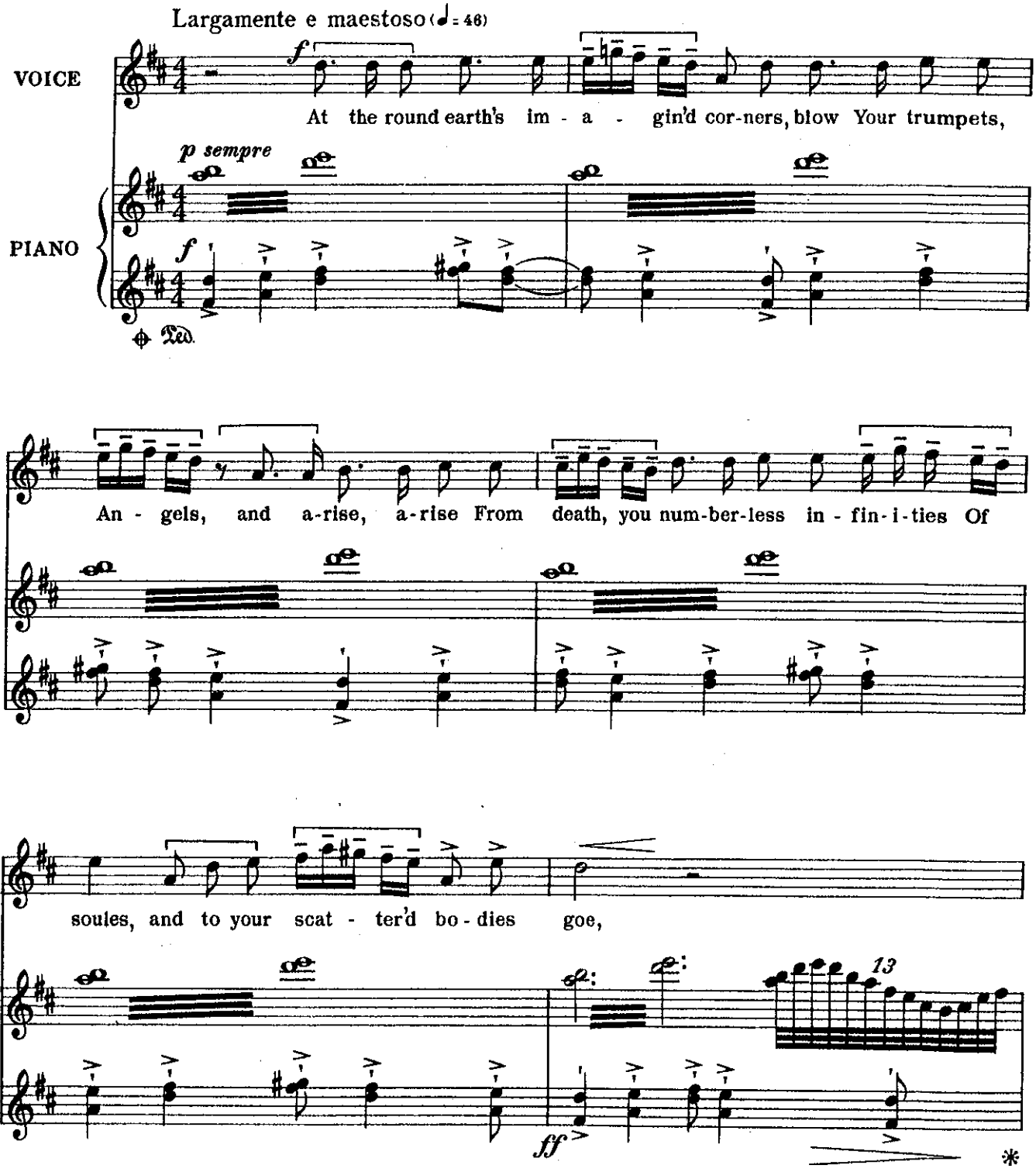



pp
Whol - ly on heavenly things my mind is sett.....
p
Here the ad-myr-ing her my mind did whett To
pp
seeke thee God;..... so streams do shew their head;
f
But though I have found thee and
mf
thou my thirst hast fed, A ho - ly thirs - ty drop - sy melts mee yett,
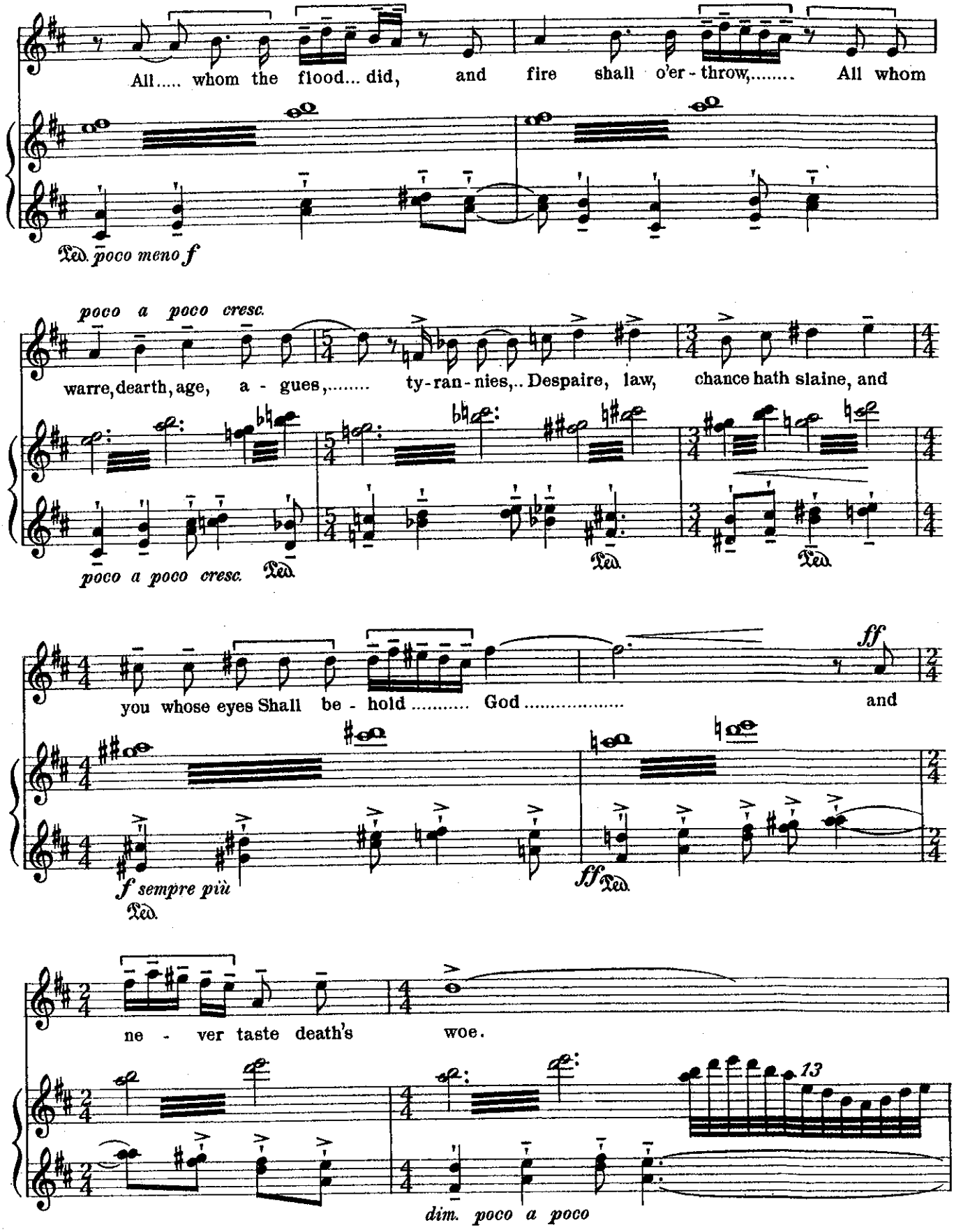

pp
But why should I begg more love,..... when as
pp
pp
poco a poco
thou Dost wooe my soul for hers: off - 'ring all thine: And dost not
pp
poco a poco
crescendo ed agitato
on - ly feare least I al - low My love to Saints and An-gels things di -
crescendo ed agitato
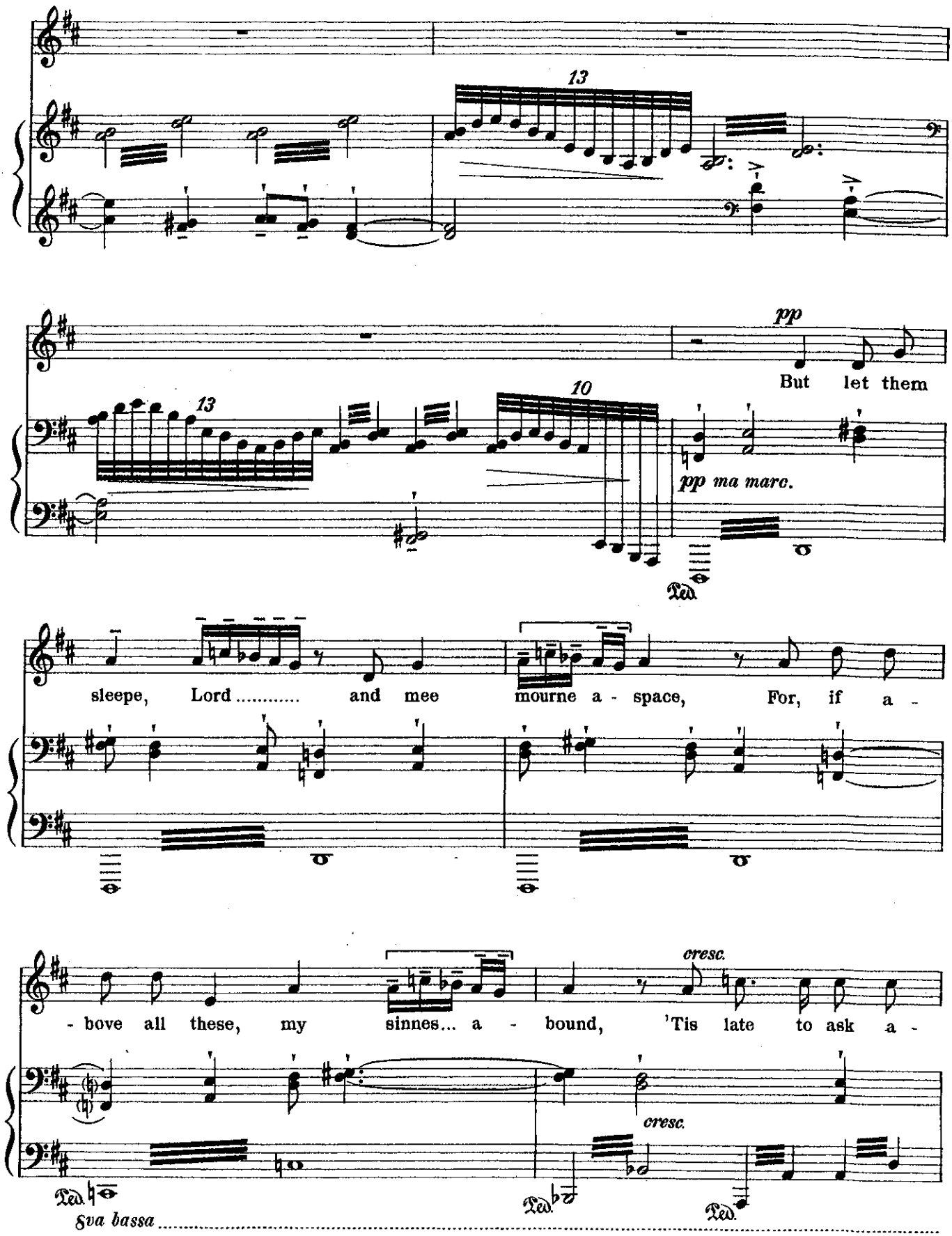

f poco largamente
- vine, But in thy ten - der jea - lo - sy dost doubt
f
dim.
Least the world, Fleshe, yea, De - vil!..... putt thee
dim.
pp
out.
p
pp
Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped. Ped.
August 8th.
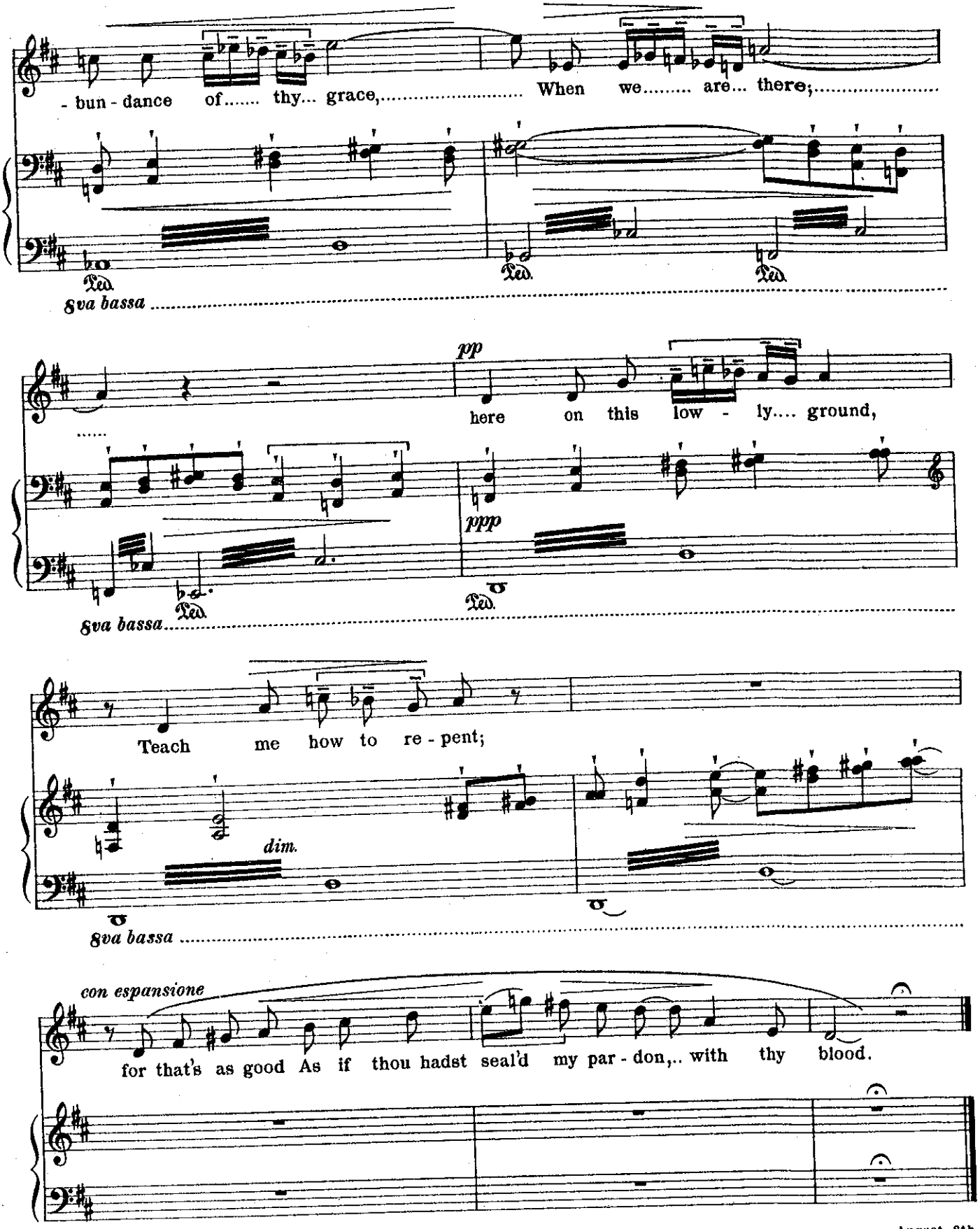
7. At the round earth's imagined corners



✣ In this Sonnet, it is essential that the Pedal should only be changed where indicated.


All..... whom the flood... did, and fire shall o'er - throw,..... All whom
poco meno f
poco a poco cresc.
warre, dearth, age, a - gues,..... ty-ran-nies,.. Despaire, law, chance hath slaine, and
poco a poco cresc.
ff
you whose eyes Shall be - hold ..... God ..... and
f sempre più
ff
ne - ver taste death's woe.
13
dim. poco a poco


13
pp
But let them
13
10
pp ma marc.
sleepe, Lord ..... and mee mourne a - space, For, if a -
- bove all these, my sinnes... a - bound, 'Tis late to ask a -
cresc.
cresc.
8va bassa
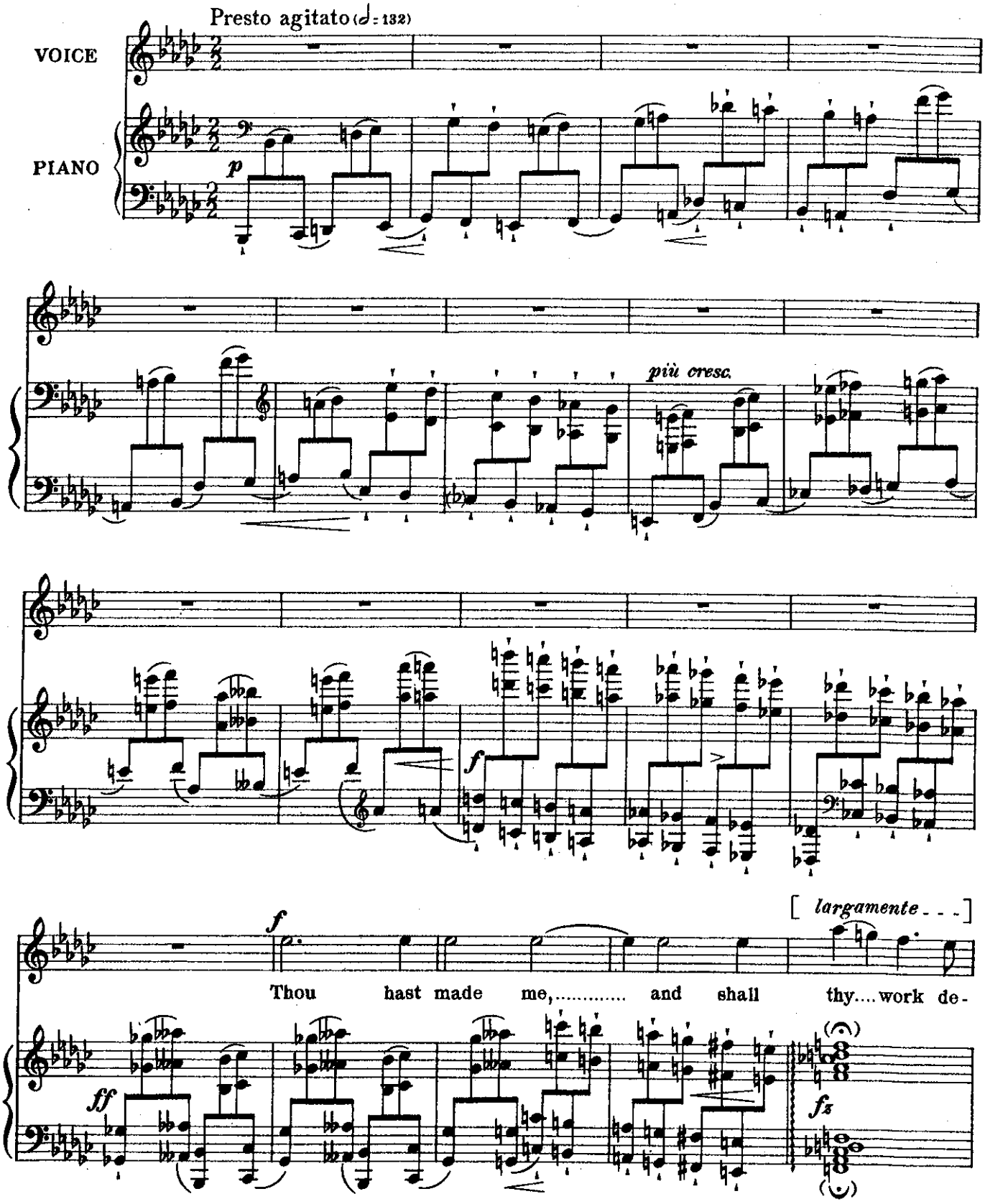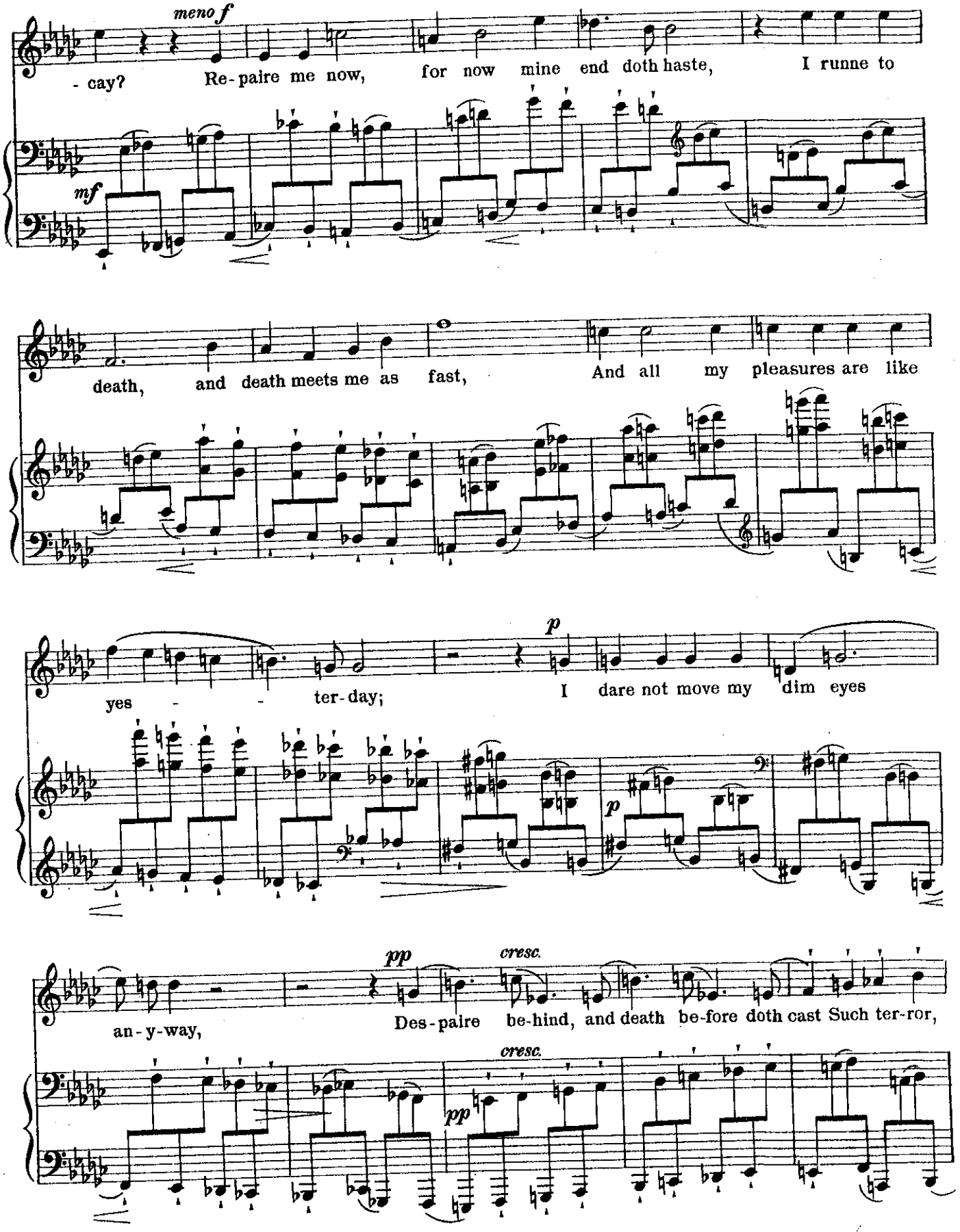


August 8th

H. 15771
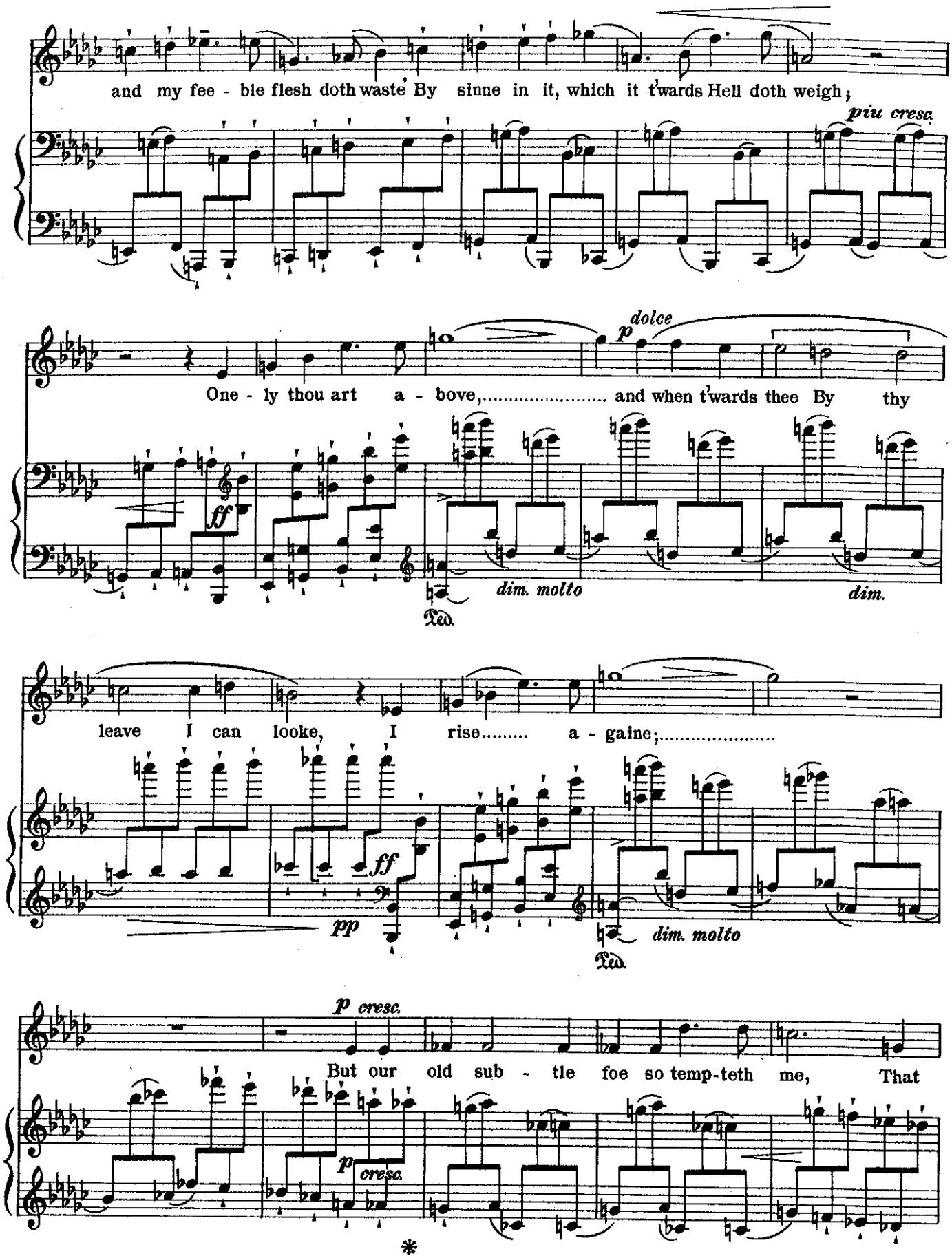
At the round earth's imagined corners

8. Thou hast made me
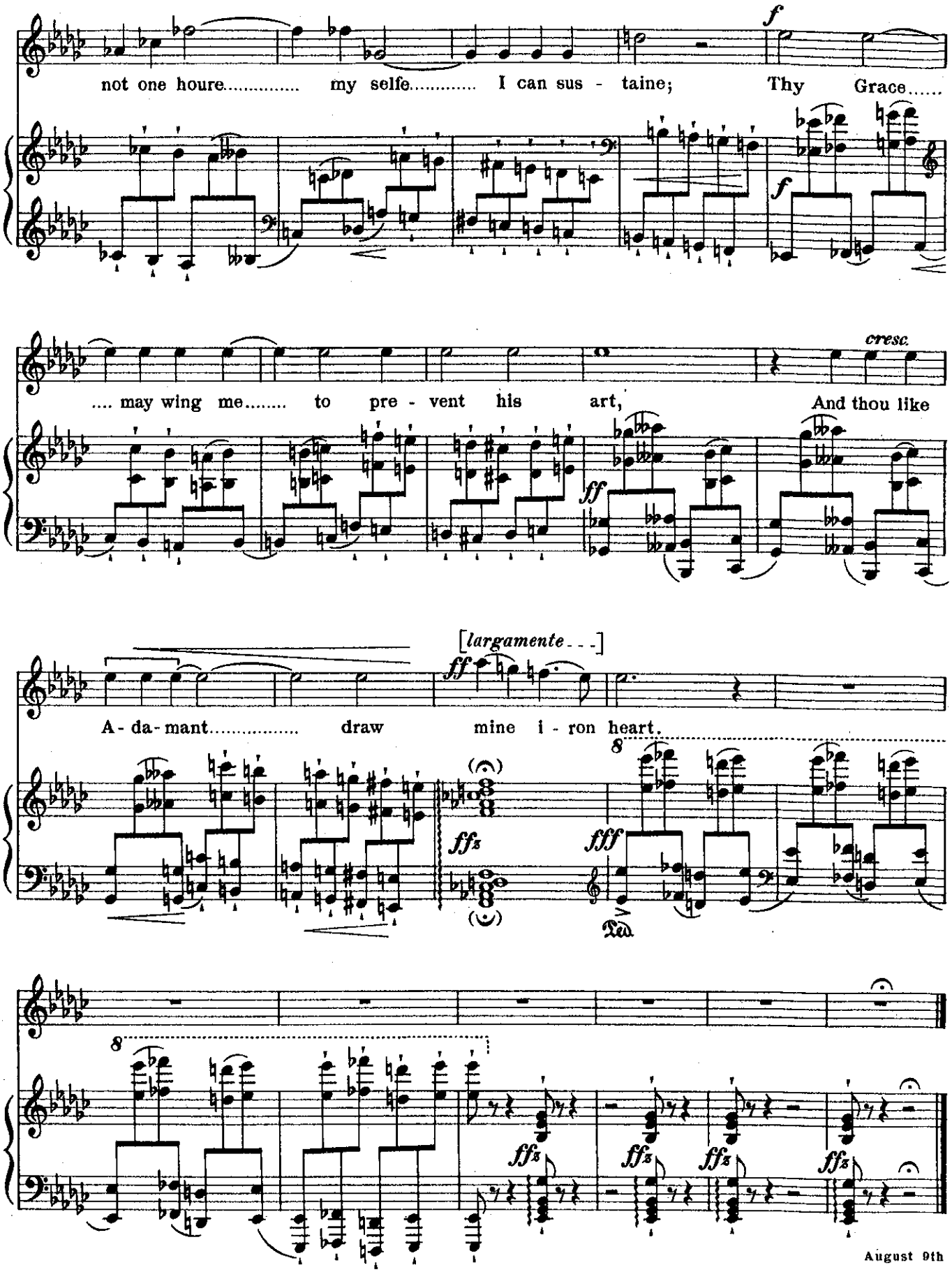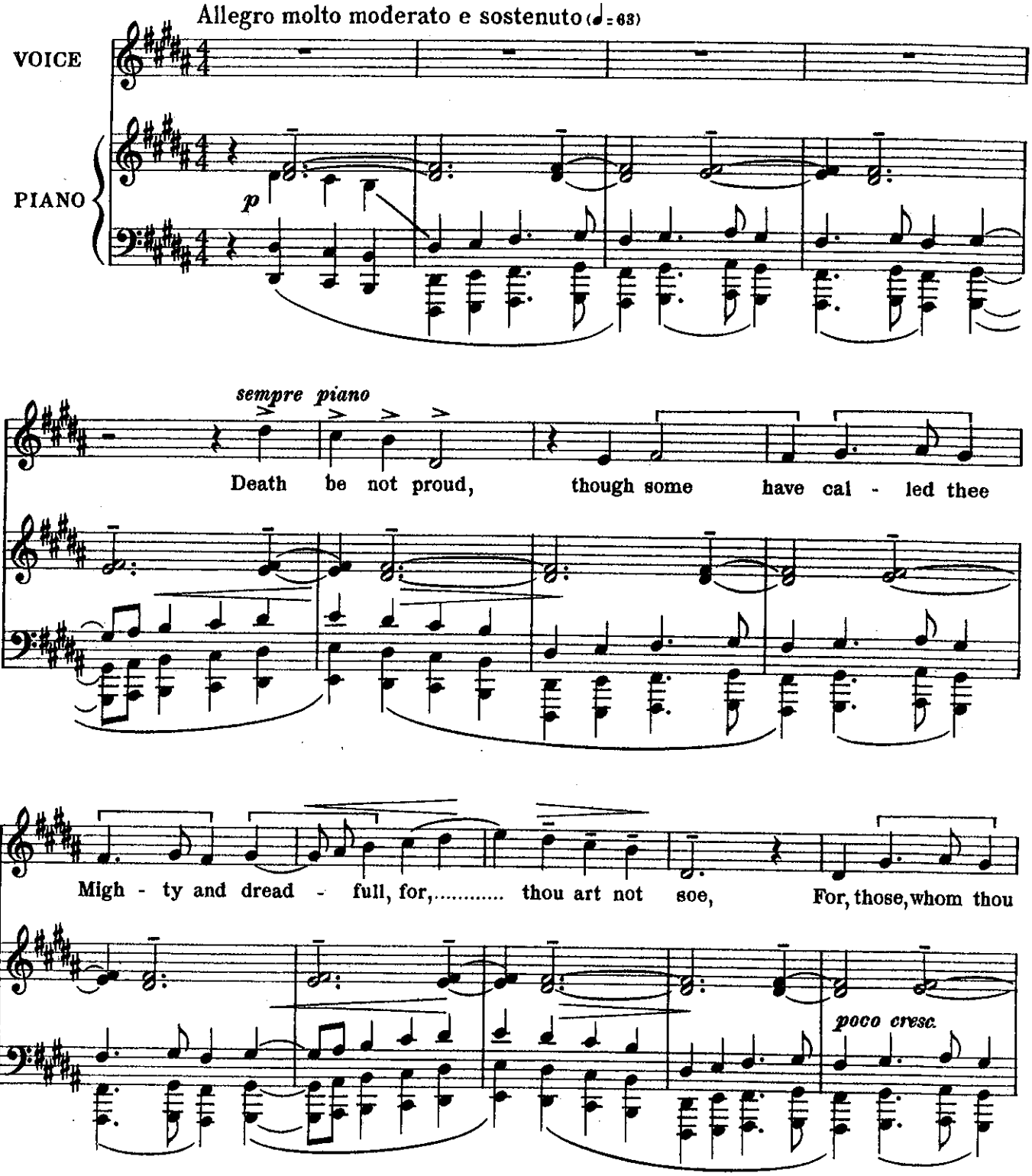




Thou hast made me
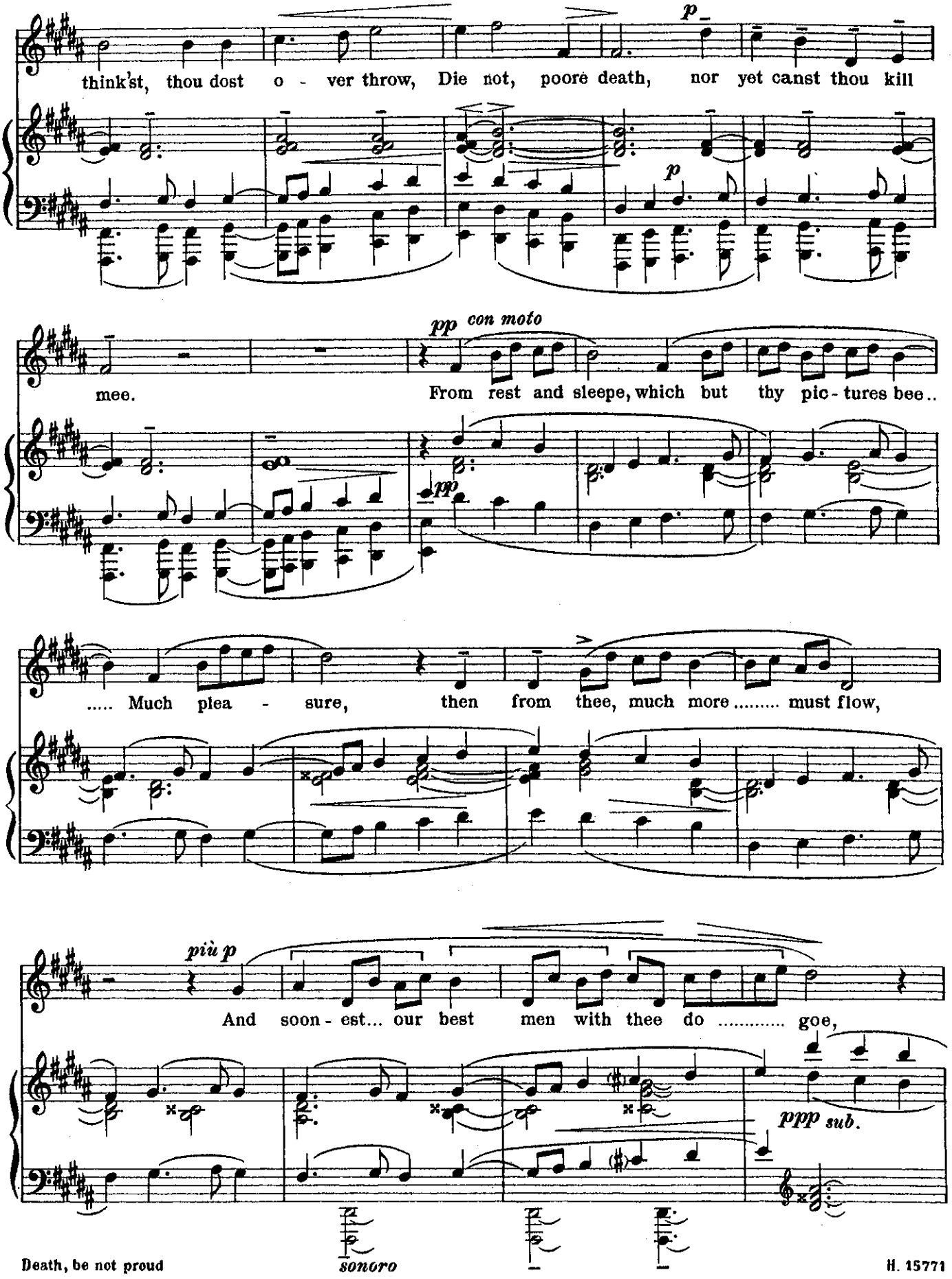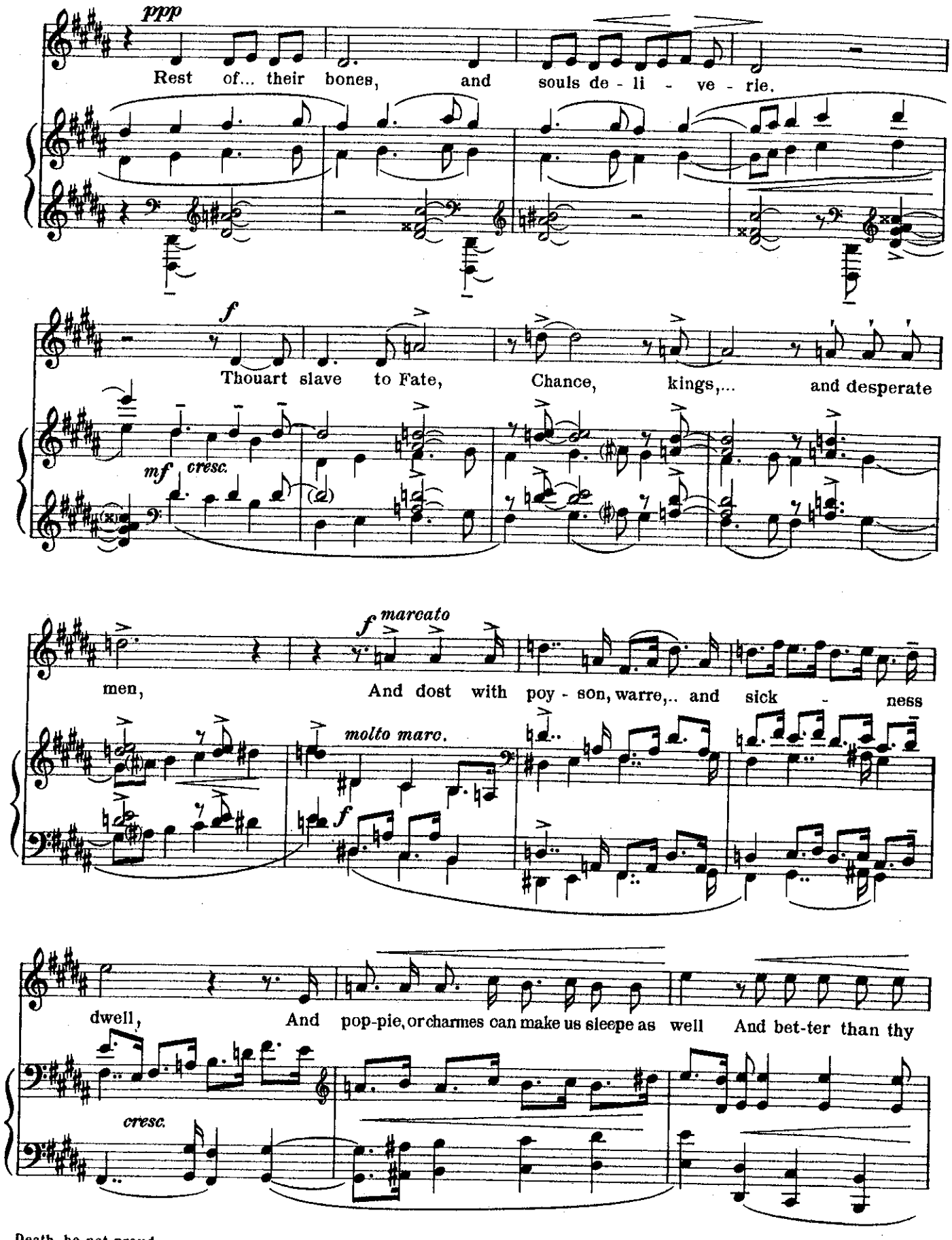


Thou hast made me
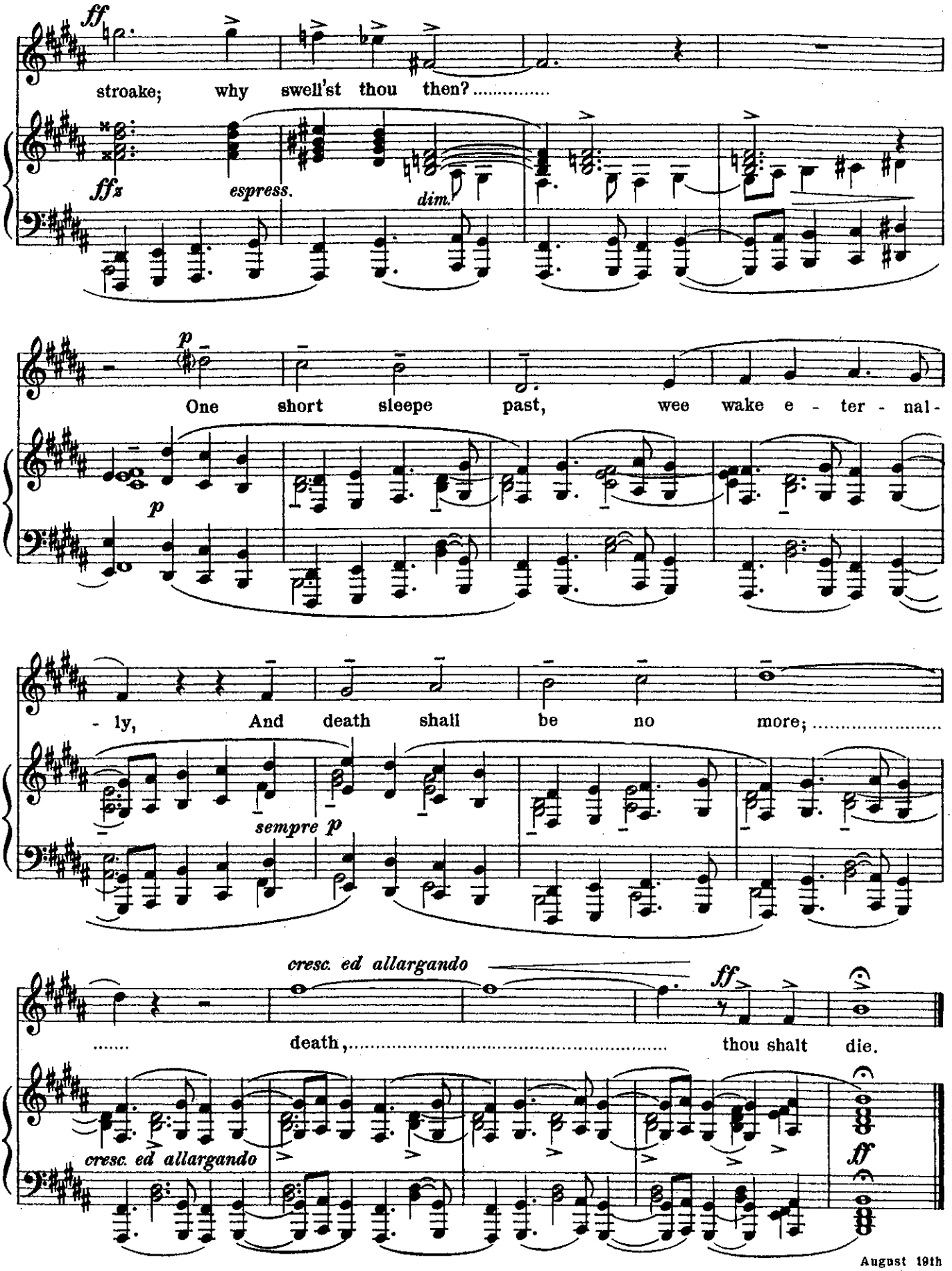

not one houre..... my selfe..... I can sus - taine; Thy Grace.....
f
f
.... may wing me..... to pre - vent his art, And thou like
cresc.
ff
A - da - mant..... draw mine i - ron heart.
[largamente...]
ff
8
ffz
fff
Ped.
8
ffz
ffz
ffz
ffz

9. Death, be not proud




think'st, thou dost o - ver throw, Die not, poore death, nor yet canst thou kill
p
p
mee.
pp con moto
From rest and sleepe, which but thy pic - tures bee..
pp
..... Much plea - sure, then from thee, much more ..... must flow,
più p
And soon - est... our best men with thee do ..... goe,
ppp sub.
sonoro


ppp
Rest of... their bones, and souls de - li - ve - rie.
f
Thouart slave to Fate, Chance, kings,... and desperate
mf cresc.
f marcato
men, And dost with poy - son, warre,.. and sick - ness
molto marc.
f
dwell, And pop-pie, or charmes can make us sleepe as well And bet-ter than thy
cresc.


ff
stroake; why swell'st thou then? .....
ffs
espress.
dim.
p
One short sleepe past, wee wake e - ter - nal -
p
- ly, And death shall be no more; .....
sempre p
cresc. ed allargando
ff
..... death, ... thou shalt die.
cresc. ed allargando
ff